CRITICAL THEORY · FEMINIST POLITICAL ECONOMY · FILM PHILOSOPHY



A DOCTORAL THESIS

The Smell That Crosses the Line

기생충

Osmocracy, Vicarious Corporeality, and the Infrahumanist Wager of Bong Joon Ho's Parasite *(2019)*



OCTOBER 2026

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Abstract

This thesis argues that Bong Joon Ho's *Parasite* (기생충, *Gisaengchung*, 2019) is not, as the critical consensus holds, a vertical allegory of class conflict, but the most rigorous cinematic anatomy yet produced of what I term the *osmocratic order*: a regime of late-capitalist domination in which rank is constituted, perceived, and policed through olfaction — the sense ranked lowest in the Western philosophical sensorium and the one sense the cinematic apparatus cannot transmit. The film itself ironizes the allegorical reading through Ki-woo's compulsive exclamation that things are "metaphorical"; I therefore relocate its critique from the level of representation to the level of the sensible.

Five interlocking theses organize the argument. First, drawing on Veblen's theory of vicarious leisure, Arendt's account of the ancient master's emancipation from necessity, and Esposito's immunitary paradigm, I propose that the Park household purchases not labor-power but *vicarious corporeality*: the delegation of the burden of embodiment — effort, fluid, dirt, dependency, odor — to others, who are then perceived as bearers of the very animality they were hired to absorb. Second, correcting Michel Serres's general parasitology with the social-reproduction feminism of Dalla Costa, James, Federici, Fraser, and Tronto, I argue that the film's ecology of parasites conceals its true host — the gendered labor of feeding, cleaning, and care — figured most nakedly in Moongwang's four-year provisioning of her husband beneath the house. Third, because the dispossessed appear in this order as odor rather than as *logos* or even

phōnē, dissensus in Rancière's sense is foreclosed: subaltern signals register as malfunction, and resistance collapses into the mute *passage à l'acte* of the knife. The nose-pinch that precipitates the killing of Park Dong-ik is read as the film's anti-humanist gesture par excellence. Fourth, tracing a subterranean genealogy from Hamlet's ghost "in the cellarage" through Hegel's and Marx's "old mole," Bataille's base materialism, and the Cold War architecture of the Korean shelter, I argue that the film records the historical closure of the underground as a space of revolutionary passage: the tunnel has become a bunker, and the mole a lamplighter. Fifth, the spectator, sealed behind the deodorizing window of the screen, occupies the structural position of the Parks; the film's final wager is that this anosmia might be felt as complicity.

Comparative readings of feminist and humanist texts — *Jane Eyre*, *The Turn of the Screw*, *Rebecca*, *The Bluest Eye*, "The Yellow Wall-Paper," *Jeanne Dielman*, *The Second Mother*, *Roma*, *Shoplifters*, *Germinal*, *The Grapes of Wrath*, *The Metamorphosis*, *Invisible Man*, and Cho Se-hui's *The Dwarf* — supply the coordinates for the thesis's culminating proposal: an *infrahumanism*, a humanism constructed not from the elevated faculties (Pico's self-fashioning, Kant's autonomy, Levinas's face) but from the shared condition of being a gravitational, leaking, odorous, dependent body. Infrahumanism names both the diagnosis the film performs and the ethical horizon it withholds.

INTRODUCTION

0

The Question of the Host

"Come on — you hear this fellow in the cellarage."
SHAKESPEARE, *HAMLET*, I.V

"Capital is dead labour, that, vampire-like, only lives by sucking living labour."
MARX, *CAPITAL*, VOL. I (1867)

"The social question is not only an ethical question, but also a question of the nose."
SIMMEL, "EXCURSUS ON THE SOCIOLOGY OF THE SENSES" (1907)

0.1 *The Doorbell in the Rain*

At the exact midpoint of *Parasite*, the Kim family occupies the absent Parks' living room, drinking their liquor and eating their food while rain sheets across the great window. The scene stages a parasitic banquet in the strict sense: the guests consume the surplus of a host who does not know they are there. Then the doorbell rings, and the former housekeeper Moon-gwang stands drenched on the monitor screen. The film turns on this sound, passing from caper to horror.

The structure is not merely analogous to, but formally identical with, the fable that opens Michel Serres's *Le Parasite* (1980). Following La Fontaine, Ser-

res describes a town rat who invites a country rat to dine on the leftovers of a tax-farmer's feast; a noise at the door interrupts the meal and scatters them. Serres's point is that the French *parasite* carries three meanings at once — the biological organism, the social sponger at another's table, and static in a channel of communication. The rats parasitize the farmer, the farmer parasitizes the peasantry, and the noise parasitizes the rats. In Bong's film the doorbell is that third parasite: interference that reveals the banquet as one link in a cascade. Within minutes the Kims will discover that the house already harbors an older parasite, a man who has lived beneath it for four years.

The question the film thereby raises — *who is the parasite?* — has dominated its reception. Is it the Kims, who infiltrate the household through forgery? Is it the Parks, who live on returns their labor did not produce? Is it Geun-sae in the bunker, or capital itself, Marx's vampire? This thesis argues that the question is badly posed. Every relation in the film is parasitic, which means the analytic task is not to identify the parasite but to locate the *host*: the unacknowledged source on which the entire cascade feeds.

0.2

Beyond the "Metaphorical"

Criticism has largely read *Parasite* as a vertical allegory, in which stairs, hills, and basements map the strata of South Korean and, by extension, global class society. The reading is correct but insufficient, and the film anticipates its insufficiency. When Ki-woo receives the scholar's stone, and repeatedly thereafter, he pronounces things "metaphorical" (the Korean 상징적이다 means, more exactly, "symbolic"). The reflex is comic because it is aspirational: the habit of reading the world as symbol is a component of the cultural capital Ki-woo lacks and wishes to perform. The film thus places the allegorical gaze in the mouth of its least reliable interpreter, ironizing in advance the critics who would read it as a diagram of class.

This self-ironization situates *Parasite* within the debate between Fredric Jameson's claim that Third World texts are necessarily "national allegories" (1986) and Aijaz Ahmad's rejoinder that the category flattens the specificity of non-Western cultural production (1987). Bong's film is legible as allegory and resistant to it. Its decisive matter lies beneath the threshold of allegory: in odor, which cannot be read; in plumbing, which carries rather than signifies; in Morse code, which transmits information below the level of language. To

read the film adequately one must descend from the symbolic to what I call the *infra*: the infra-sensible, the infrastructural, and the infra-linguistic.

0.3
The Five Theses

The argument proceeds through five theses that together compose a single original framework. The first is *osmocracy* (from Greek *osmē*, odor, and *kratos*, rule): a regime in which social rank is sensed and naturalized through smell. Credentials, clothing, and speech can be counterfeited, as the Kims demonstrate with ease; odor cannot. Smell is therefore the final, uncounterfeitable index of class, and the film's plot is organized as a progressive olfactory exposure.

The second is *vicarious corporeality*. Thorstein Veblen observed that the leisure class delegates leisure and consumption to wives and servants, who perform them "vicariously" on the master's behalf (1899). I extend the concept: the contemporary bourgeoisie delegates not merely leisure but embodiment itself — sweat, effort, dirt, fluid, dependency, and smell. What the Parks purchase is exemption from the body. The bitter dialectic is that those who absorb this burden are then perceived as constitutionally embodied, as the bearers of an animality that is in fact the master's own, outsourced.

The third is the *reproductive host*. Serres treats parasitism as the elementary relation of the social, but his account is gender-blind. Read through social-reproduction feminism, the cascade of parasites in *Parasite* rests on a single unremunerated foundation: the labor of feeding, cleaning, and care. Its emblem is Moon-gwang, who for four years carries food from the master's refrigerator down to the husband hidden beneath the house.

The fourth is the *bunkered mole*. Hamlet hears his father's ghost moving under the stage; Hegel and Marx borrow the "old mole" as a figure for Spirit and revolution burrowing toward the surface; Bataille opposes the mole's base materialism to the Icarian eagle of idealism. In each case the underground is a passage. In *Parasite* it has become a sealed Cold War shelter, and its inhabitant no longer tunnels but flickers the master's lights in homage. The film registers the closure of the subterranean as a space of history.

The fifth is *anosmic spectatorship*. Cinema addresses only what Hegel called the "theoretical senses," sight and hearing; it cannot transmit smell. The spectator thus watches the Kims as the Parks do, through a deodorizing window. The film's formal wager is to make this immunity perceptible as complicity.

These five theses converge on a proposal I call *infrahumanism*. The term deliberately détourns "infrahumanization," the social-psychological concept introduced by Jacques-Philippe Leyens and colleagues around 2000 to describe the attribution of a lesser humanity to out-groups. Where infrahumanization denies full humanity from above, infrahumanism grounds humanity from below: in the shared condition of being a gravitational, leaking, odorous, dependent body. The film does not affirm this humanism; it demonstrates, with terrible precision, the cost of its absence.

0.4

Method and Corpus

Methodologically, the thesis proceeds by constellation in the sense of Benjamin and Adorno: rather than applying one theory to the film, it assembles heterogeneous traditions around the film until a configuration becomes legible. These traditions include dialectical materialism (Marx, Engels, Lukács, Adorno, Jameson); the phenomenology and poetics of space (Bachelard, Heidegger, Lefebvre); the sensory history of class and race (Simmel, Elias, Corbin, Classen, Mark M. Smith); feminist political economy and care ethics (Federici, Fraser, Tronto, Hochschild, Glenn, Anderson); psychoanalysis (Freud, Lacan, Kristeva); and contemporary political philosophy (Rancière, Esposito, Arendt, Spivak, Wynter).

The comparative corpus spans the servant narrative from Lucian and Plautus to Genet, Losey, and Chabrol; the Korean tradition from Kim Ki-young's *The Housemaid* (1960) and Cho Se-hui's *The Dwarf* (1978) to Lee Chang-dong's *Burning* (2018); and the feminist and humanist canons named in the abstract. Attention is paid throughout to the gap between Korean dialogue and Darcy Paquet's English subtitles, which rendered Seoul National University as "Oxford" and the instant-noodle hybrid *jjapaguri* as "ram-don." That translational gap is itself a site of class semiotics.

0.5

Plan of the Work

Chapter 1 reconstructs the film's genealogies: Bong's formation as a sociology student, the compressed modernity of South Korea, the urban history of the semi-basement, the archive of servant revolts, and the philology of the title. Chapter 2 develops a parasitological history from Aristotle to Serres and Fraser

and proposes a "critical bestiary." Chapter 3 analyzes the film's vertical ontology: stairs, cellar and attic, glass architecture, the hydraulics of flood, and the passage from tunnel to bunker. Chapter 4 constructs the theory of osmocracy. Chapter 5 reads the household through feminist political economy and feminist literature and film. Chapter 6 treats the climactic birthday party as a sacrificial feast. Chapter 7 confronts the humanist tradition and elaborates infrahumanism. Chapter 8 addresses form, genre, reception, and the anosmic screen. The conclusion returns to the final image: a son planning to buy the ground in which his father is buried.

CHAPTER ONE

1

Genealogies

The Sociologist, the Semi-Basement, and the Servant's Revolt

1.1
The Sociologist with a Camera

Bong Joon Ho entered Yonsei University to study sociology in 1988, in the immediate aftermath of the June Democratic Struggle that ended South Korea's military dictatorship. The formation matters. Bong's cinema is the work of what C. Wright Mills called the *sociological imagination* (1959): the capacity to grasp private troubles as public issues and biography as an intersection with history. It is no accident that the forged enrollment certificate on which the Kims' entire enterprise rests is a Yonsei document. The director inscribes his own credential at the origin of the con, as though to concede that the cultural capital authorizing his critique is of the same order as the counterfeit he depicts.

Two further strands of the genealogy deserve note. Bong's maternal grandfather was Park Taewon (1909–1986), a central figure of Korean literary modernism whose *A Day in the Life of Kubo the Novelist* (1934) installed the Benjaminian flâneur in colonial Seoul, and whose *Scenes from the Ch'ŏnggye Stream* (1936) offered a panoramic anatomy of the city's lower orders along a single urban waterway. The grandson's film ends with a stone returned to a stream. Bong has also recounted that as a student he briefly tutored a middle-school boy in a wealthy household, a position obtained through the woman who became his wife, from which he was soon dismissed. The autobiographical kernel

is precisely the film's point of entry: the tutor as the first breach in the household's wall.

Bong has described conceiving the project around 2013 as a stage play, and its working title was reportedly *Decalcomania*, after the technique of folding paint between paper to produce a mirror image. The title encodes the film's architecture of doubles: two four-member families, father, mother, son, daughter, reflected across a class divide, and a third couple, Moon-gwang and Geun-sae, as a ghost-image in the fold. Across Bong's filmography the subterranean recurs with the insistence of a signature. *Barking Dogs Never Bite* (2000) circulates a legend of a man buried in an apartment complex's basement walls; *Memories of Murder* (2003) finds bodies in drainage culverts; *The Host* (2006) raises its creature from the Han River's sewers after a dumping of formaldehyde modeled on a real 2000 incident involving a US military mortuary; *Snowpiercer* (2013) lays class on its side as a train; *Okja* (2017) descends into the slaughterhouse; *Mickey 17* (2025) imagines a worker literally reprinted after each death. If *Snowpiercer* laid class horizontally, *Parasite* stands it upright.

1.2
Compressed Modernity and the Grammar of Despair

The sociologist Chang Kyung-Sup has described South Korea's development as *compressed modernity*: transformations that took Western societies two centuries were achieved in roughly four decades, so that premodern, modern, and postmodern formations coexist in a single social space (2010). The Park house is a monument to this compression. A Confucian scholar's stone, a Cold War civil-defense shelter, a modernist glass façade, an IT executive's family, and a child's cowboys-and-Indians fantasy imported from the United States cohabit under one roof. Ernst Bloch's formula for Weimar Germany, the "simultaneity of the non-simultaneous" (*Erbschaft dieser Zeit*, 1935), describes it exactly.

The Asian financial crisis of 1997, which South Koreans still call the "IMF crisis," accelerated a neoliberal restructuring that dualized the labor market between regular and non-regular workers and pushed laid-off men into small self-employment. The meme that every Korean career path ends in a fried-chicken shop condenses this history, and the film knows it. Ki-taek's résumé of failure includes a chicken restaurant and a Taiwanese castella franchise, the confectionery fad that boomed around 2016 and collapsed in 2017 after a damaging television exposé. Geun-sae, it emerges, was a casualty of the same boom; he hides in the bunker from loan sharks. The two men are bound not by blood but

by the same bankrupt franchise model, and by a household debt burden that ranks among the highest in the developed world.

By 2015 Korean youth had coined a grammar of despair to name this order. "Hell Joseon" (헬조선) cast the nation as an infernal revival of the hereditary Joseon dynasty. "Spoon class theory" (수저계급론) sorted citizens by the spoon they were born with, gold for the heirs and dirt (흙수저) for the rest. The "N-po generation" gave up, successively, dating, marriage, children, homeownership, and hope. Education fever produced its own folk sociology: a child's admission to an elite university, the saying goes, requires the grandfather's wealth, the mother's information network, and the father's indifference. The Park household realizes this triad almost to the letter: inherited ease, Yeon-kyo's "belt of trust," and Park Dong-ik's complete detachment from his children's formation.

Korean public discourse also furnished the vocabulary of *gap* and *eul* (갑/을), the contractual designations of "party A" and "party B" repurposed after 2013 to name domination, and *gapjil* (갑질), the abusive exercise of the superior position. The emblematic scandal was the 2014 "nut rage" incident, in which an airline heiress forced a taxiing jet back to the gate over the serving of macadamia nuts. Bong's decisive choice is to deny his audience such a villain. The Parks are courteous, generous with overtime, and attentive to their help's competence. As Chung-sook remarks in rebuttal of her husband, Yeon-kyo is not kind *despite* being rich but *because* she is rich; wealth, in her image, is an iron that presses out the creases. The cruelty of the film is not *gapjil* but something more refined and more total: the polite, involuntary recoil of the nose.

1.3
From Moon Village to Semi-Basement

The film's vertical schema records a historical inversion in the topography of Seoul. In the decades of rapid industrialization, rural migrants built hillside shantytowns known as *daldongne* (달동네), "moon villages," so called because they stood high enough to seem near the moon. Successive waves of redevelopment from the 1980s onward cleared these settlements for apartment complexes and enclaves of the affluent, a process whose violence culminated in the 2009 Yongsan disaster, in which a police raid on evicted tenants occupying a rooftop ended in a fire that killed five protesters and one officer. The poor were driven from the hill into the ground. Cho Se-hui's *The Dwarf* (1978), the canonical Korean novel of redevelopment, gives this history its myth: a dwarf whose

family is evicted dreams of launching a small ball toward the moon and dies falling from a factory chimney. The moon descended into the semi-basement.

The *banjiha* (반지하), or semi-basement flat, has a documented genealogy in Cold War civil defense. In the wake of the 1968 commando raid on the Blue House by North Korean special forces, building regulations of the early 1970s required new low-rise residential buildings to include underground spaces usable as shelters. The housing shortages of the following decade led to their legalization as rental dwellings. The Kims' home and the Parks' bunker are thus architectural siblings, born of the same mandate to shelter the nation from the North. One became the dwelling of the poor; the other, hidden beneath a modernist villa, became the hiding place of a debtor. Youth discourse of the 2010s named the trinity of substandard housing *jiokgo* (지옥고), a portmanteau of semi-basement, rooftop room, and *gosiwon* cubicle that puns on *jiok*, hell. The poor occupy both extremes of the building, the basement and the roof, while the rich occupy the elevation of the hill: Bong's verticality is topographical, not merely architectural.

Reality subsequently annotated the film. In August 2022, record rainfall flooded semi-basement flats across Seoul; in Gwanak district three members of one family, including a teenager, drowned in their banjiha. The Seoul Metropolitan Government announced plans to phase out semi-basement dwellings. A film once received as an exaggerated allegory was retroactively confirmed as documentary.

1.4
The Archive of the Servant's Revolt

Parasite belongs to a transnational archive of narratives in which domestic servants turn upon the household. Its founding event is the crime of 2 February 1933 in Le Mans, when Christine and Léa Papin, live-in maids in the Lancelin household, beat their employer's wife, Léonie Lancelin, and her daughter, Geneviève, to death. The detail that matters here is the trigger: an iron that blew the household's fuses, plunging the house into darkness on the employers' return. Lacan's early essay on the case, "Motifs du crime paranoïaque" (1933), read it as a paranoiac *folie à deux*, a fusion of the sisters into a single delusional subject. Chung-sook's image of money as an iron, and the film's flickering lights, belong to this lineage of domestic electricity.

Genet's *Les Bonnes* (1947) transposed the Papin case into a ritual in which two maids rehearse the murder of Madame by playing her, a theater of mimicry

that anticipates the Kims' rehearsals. Joseph Losey and Harold Pinter's *The Servant* (1963) inverts master and manservant in a Chelsea townhouse through a staircase dramaturgy; there the servant introduces his lover as his sister, a fabricated kinship that mirrors the Kims' concealed one. Ruth Rendell's *A Judgement in Stone* (1977), whose title curiously anticipates Bong's stone, announces in its first sentence that a housekeeper murdered her employers because she could not read; Claude Chabrol's adaptation, *La Cérémonie* (1995), has its illiterate maid and her accomplice shoot the bourgeois family while it watches *Don Giovanni* on television, a literalization of Benjamin's dictum that every document of civilization is also a document of barbarism.

The Korean ancestor, which Bong has repeatedly honored, is Kim Ki-young's *The Housemaid* (1960). A composer who teaches music to female factory workers moves his family into a new two-story house financed by his wife's sewing; a housemaid drawn from the factory seduces him; rat poison and a fatal staircase complete the catastrophe. Kim's film already contains the essential coordinates: the stair as class threshold, the feminized home economy, vermin, and the new house as an object of desire. Im Sang-soo's remake (2010) relocated the drama to a chaebol mansion. Bong's decisive departure is to desexualize the infiltration. Where Kim's maid is a femme fatale embodying male anxiety about female and lower-class desire, Bong's infiltrators are a family firm, and the threat they carry is not seduction but smell.

The literary lineage extends further. In Zola's *Germinal* (1885), the Grégoires live comfortably on dividends from a mining share inherited since the eighteenth century; when their daughter Cécile pays a charitable visit to a miner's home, the paralyzed old miner Bonnemort strangles her in a wordless, unexplained act. In H. G. Wells's *The Time Machine* (1895), the class divide has speciated humanity into the surface-dwelling Eloi and the subterranean Morlocks, who emerge at night to feed. In Fritz Lang's *Metropolis* (1927), workers inhabit a city beneath the city, and their uprising floods their own quarter. J. G. Ballard's *High-Rise* (1975) turns a residential tower into a vertical class war. *Parasite* condenses this archive into a single house.

1.5
The Philology of a Title

The Korean title, 기생충 (*gisaengchung*), is composed of the Sino-Korean characters 寄 (to lodge with, to depend upon), 生 (to live), and 蟲 (insect, worm, vermin). Its Greek counterpart, *parasitos*, means "one who eats beside": *para*,

beside, and *sitos*, grain. Originally a cultic official entitled to share the sacred meal, the *parasitos* became in New Comedy the stock figure of the flatterer who sings for his supper.

The final syllable, *chung*, carries a charge specific to the decade of the film's making. In South Korean online discourse of the 2010s, the suffix *-chung* (-충) proliferated as a generalized marker of contempt: *mamchung* (맘충) for mothers deemed entitled, *geupsikchung* (급식충) for adolescents, *teulttakchung* (틀딱충) for the elderly, *ilbechung* (일베충) for users of a far-right forum, and *hannam-chung* (한남충), the feminist counter-insult for Korean men. Alongside it ran a misogynist lexicon of female parasitism, from *doenjangnyeo* (된장녀, 2006), the woman who allegedly starves on cheap stew to afford luxury coffee, to *kim-chinyeo* (김치녀), the woman who allegedly lives off men. A society that verminized its own members by age, gender, and politics produced a film that names the verminizing gaze in its title.

A further resonance, which I propose as a reading rather than an attribution of intention, lies in Korean homophony. 寄生, parasitism, is written 기생 in hangul; so is 妓生, *kisaeng*, women of the Joseon period registered with the state as lowborn *cheonmin*, trained in poetry, music, dance, and painting, and obliged to entertain officials and *yangban* men, a service that could include sex. In the 1970s the name was attached to "kisaeng tourism": organized sex tourism in which mostly Japanese men bought sex from Korean women, and which the Park Chung-hee government encouraged as a source of foreign currency; Korean Church Women United protested it publicly from 1973. The homophone exposes a gendered archaeology of parasitism: a woman's body and her cultivated arts sold, with the state's encouragement, to men with money. Ki-jung, who impersonates an art therapist and then uses her own underwear as an instrument of the con, is her modern descendant. In the same homophonic register, Ki-woo's name sounds as *giu* (杞憂), the classical idiom for groundless anxiety; the narrative ironizes it by proving every anxiety grounded.

Finally, a translational curiosity. In English, Bong's 2006 film is *The Host*, though its Korean title is simply 괴물, "monster"; his 2019 film is *Parasite*. Read through its English titles, the oeuvre stages the Serresian couple of host and parasite, a pairing that exists only in translation. That the critical apparatus of this thesis begins in an accident of translation is fitting for a film whose international career would be governed, as Chapter 8 shows, by the politics of the subtitle.

CHAPTER TWO

2

The Parasitological Imagination

From the Animate Tool to the Noise in the Channel

2.1
The Art of the Parasite

The parasite entered Western letters as a comic professional. Plautus's Peniculus ("Little Brush," for the way he sweeps tables clean) in the *Menaechmi* and Ergasilus in *The Captives*, and Terence's Gnatho in the *Eunuch*, are specialists in flattery whose livelihood is the meal at another's table. Lucian of Samosata pushed the type to its theoretical limit in his dialogue *The Parasite*, in which the parasite Simon argues, with Socratic method, that parasitism is a genuine *technē*, an art with its own end and its own mastery, superior to rhetoric and philosophy.

The Kims are Lucianic technicians. Their operation depends on demonstrable craft: Ki-jung's digital forgery of the Yonsei certificate, her improvised mastery of art-therapy jargon, Ki-woo's pedagogical theater of "seizing the flow" of an exam, the choreographed relay of recommendations that installs each family member in turn. Ki-taek's admiring quip on seeing the forged document, asking whether the national university offers a department of document forgery, is rendered in the English subtitles as a question about Oxford, a substitution that globalizes the elite referent while preserving the joke's logic. The quip names the film's first thesis: in a credential society, forgery is a professional skill, and the parasite is a craftsman of access.

2.2
The Animate Tool

Aristotle opens the *Politics* with the household, the *oikos*, and defines the slave as a "living possession" and an animate instrument, an *organon empsychon* (*Politics* I.4). The natural slave, in his notorious doctrine, is one who participates in reason enough to apprehend it but not to possess it, and whose body is fitted for necessary labor. Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) draws the consequence: in antiquity, freedom from necessity was purchased through the domination of others who bore necessity for the free. To labor meant to be enslaved by the body's cycle of consumption and reproduction; the master's freedom was the slave's burden, displaced.

The Park household is an *oikos* in this precise sense. Its members are liberated from cooking, cleaning, driving, tutoring, and even the emotional labor of reading their children's psyches, which they purchase from an art therapist. Moon-gwang belongs to an older stratum still. She served the house's architect, Namgoong Hyeonja, and passed to the Parks with the property, like a fixture. The medieval law of serfdom called this condition *adscriptio glebae*, attachment to the soil. A servant who comes with the house is a feudal residue embedded in a modernist villa, another instance of compressed modernity.

2.3
The Political Economy of the Menial

Classical political economy relegated the domestic servant to the category of *unproductive labor*. Adam Smith's formulation is pitiless: "A man grows rich by employing a multitude of manufacturers: he grows poor, by maintaining a multitude of menial servants" (*Wealth of Nations*, II.iii, 1776). The servant's labor, in Smith's analysis, perishes in the moment of its performance and fixes itself in no vendible commodity. Saint-Simon inverted the moral polarity in his "Parable" (1819), arguing that France would suffer no real loss if its royal family, ministers, and great proprietors died overnight, but would be ruined by the death of its three thousand leading scientists, artists, and artisans. For Saint-Simon the idle elite, the *oisifs*, were the true parasites.

Marx radicalized both moves. Capital itself is the parasite, "dead labour" that lives vampire-like on living labor (*Capital* I, ch. 10). Yet Marx also observed, in his analysis of machinery, that the English census of 1861 counted more members of the "servant class" than workers in the textile factories and

mines combined, a sardonic proof that industrial productivity had multiplied what he called modern domestic slaves (*Capital* I, ch. 15). The domestic servant thus occupies a contradictory position in Marxist theory: indispensable to bourgeois reproduction, yet outside the circuit of surplus-value that defines the proletariat proper.

Marx's typology of the *relative surplus population* in chapter 25 of *Capital* maps the film's underclass with remarkable precision. The *floating* surplus population, intermittently employed and discarded, describes Ki-taek, who has cycled through chauffeuring, fried chicken, and castella. The *stagnant* surplus population, whose employment is extremely irregular and who sink toward pauperism, describes Geun-sae, who has fallen out of the labor market altogether into the "hospital" of the reserve army. And the *lumpenproletariat*, which Marx described with mingled fascination and disgust in *The Eighteenth Brumaire* (1852) as a heterogeneous mass of the déclassé, the swindlers and the improvisers, is the class to which the Kims' con assigns them in the eyes of law. The reserve army, Marx insisted, disciplines the employed through competition. The Kims do not attack the Parks; they displace Mr. Yoon, the chauffeur, and Moon-gwang, the housekeeper. I call this *lateral parasitism*: the predation of the dispossessed upon one another for positions within the same household.

2.4
The Lethal Career of a Metaphor

No term in the vocabulary of social critique has been more reversible, or more murderous, than "parasite." Aimed upward, it indicts rentiers, aristocrats, and capital, as in Saint-Simon and Marx. Aimed downward, it has served to authorize extermination. Alex Bein's essay "The Jewish Parasite" (1964) traced how the biological metaphor migrated into antisemitic discourse until National Socialism spoke of Jews as parasites on the body of the *Volk*. Hitler's *Mein Kampf* (1925) called the Jew a parasite in the body of other peoples, and the propaganda film *Der ewige Jude* (1940), made under Goebbels's ministry, cut images of Jews against images of swarming rats. That vocabulary of parasites and vermin served the dehumanization that prepared and accompanied the Holocaust, in which Nazi Germany and its collaborators murdered about six million Jews. In 1961 the Soviet Union decreed penalties for "social parasitism" (*tuneyadstvo*), under which the poet Joseph Brodsky was tried and sentenced to internal exile in 1964 for failing to hold regular employment; the artist, too, could be a parasite. Libertarian fiction offered its own inversion in Ayn Rand's *Atlas Shrugged*

(1957), where the parasites are the "looters" and "moochers" who live off the productive. The Korean *-chung* lexicon described in Chapter 1 is this metaphor's most recent vernacular form.

Bong's title refuses to fix the vector of the accusation. It neither names the Kims as parasites nor indicts the Parks; it suspends the word over the entire social field. This suspension is not equivocation but exposure: the reversibility of the term is itself the structure the film depicts, a world in which every party is plausibly the parasite of another and the accusation merely tracks the direction of power.

2.5

Serres: The Host Is the Guest

Serres's *Le Parasite* supplies the theoretical grammar for this suspension. In French, *hôte* designates both host and guest; the language refuses to decide who gives and who receives. Serres argues that the parasitic relation is the elementary atom of the social: an "abusive" relation of one-way flow, an arrow that takes without returning. The parasite is not a pathology of the system but its condition of possibility. Every channel has noise; every exchange has a third who intercepts; and systems become complex precisely by integrating their parasites. The parasite, moreover, parasitizes the parasite, producing cascades in which each link feeds on the one below while being fed upon from above.

The film is a Serresian machine. Its opening scene finds Ki-woo and Ki-jung hunting the house for a Wi-Fi signal, an informational parasitism of the neighbors' network, and discovering it only when they climb onto the elevated toilet. Their first employment is piecework folding cardboard boxes for a pizza chain, an outwork economy that feeds on their unpaid time. The Kims then parasitize the Parks, while the Parks parasitize everyone; Geun-sae parasitizes the refrigerator; Moon-gwang parasitizes her employers to sustain him. And the motion-sensor lights on the stairs, which Geun-sae triggers with his head to spell out messages in Morse code, are parasites in the third, informational sense: signal disguised as noise, which the master dismisses as an electrical fault.

2.6

The Cannibal and the Host

Serres's cascade is gender-blind. It does not ask what feeds the bottom of the chain. Nancy Fraser's account of capitalism as an institutionalized social or-

der provides the answer. Capital, she argues, free-rides on "background conditions" it neither produces nor replenishes: social reproduction (the unpaid and underpaid work of birthing, raising, feeding, and caring for human beings), nature, and public power ("Contradictions of Capital and Care," 2016). In *Cannibal Capitalism* (2022) she radicalizes the metaphor: the system devours the very conditions of its own existence. The vampire, the parasite, and the cannibal form a triad of critical figures, but only Fraser's locates the host in reproductive labor. Chapter 5 develops this correction in full. Here it suffices to state its consequence: in *Parasite*, the hidden host is not the Park fortune but the care that keeps every body in the film alive.

2.7

Symbiosis and Its Discontents

Biology no longer treats parasitism as an essence. It is one position on a continuum of symbiosis that runs from mutualism, in which both partners benefit, through commensalism, in which one benefits without harm to the other, to parasitism, in which one benefits at the other's expense. Lynn Margulis's theory of symbiogenesis argued that the complex cell itself arose through the incorporation of bacteria that became mitochondria and chloroplasts (*Symbiotic Planet*, 1998); life is built from former parasites turned partners. Donna Haraway's concept of *sympoiesis*, "making-with," extends the lesson to a feminist ethics of kinship across difference (*Staying with the Trouble*, 2016).

This framework discloses the film's most subversive implication. The Kims are good at their jobs. Ki-taek drives with a smoothness his employer praises; Chung-sook runs the household superbly; Ki-jung calms a child no previous tutor could manage; Ki-woo engages a pupil his predecessor merely charmed. The fraud lies not in the labor but in the credential that grants access to it. What looks like parasitism is, at the level of the work performed, mutualism: the Parks receive excellent service; the Kims receive wages. The relation appears parasitic only because access to it is monopolized through what Max Weber called social closure and what Charles Tilly called opportunity hoarding (*Durable Inequality*, 1998). The question the film poses is therefore not *who is the parasite* but *why a possible symbiosis must take the form of parasitism* — and the answer is that closure converts competence without pedigree into theft.

2.8

A Critical Bestiary

The film teems with animals, each naming a relation rather than an essence. The vampire is Marx's capital, which the Parks embody without ever drinking blood. The parasite is Serres's third, the elementary relation itself. The cannibal is Fraser's system, consuming its own conditions. The vermin is Kafka's Gregor Samsa and the Korean *-chung*, the human reclassified as pest; the opening sequence shows a municipal truck spraying insecticide down the street while Ki-taek tells his family to leave the windows open for a free extermination of the stinkbugs. The cockroach is Chung-sook's own simile: were the Parks to come home suddenly, she tells her husband, he would scatter like a roach when the light comes on. The mole, figure of Hamlet's ghost, of Hegel's Spirit, and of Marx's revolution, survives in degraded form as the bunker's inhabitant. The household's lapdogs enjoy an intimacy with the family that no employee is permitted, eating in the kitchen and lying on its laps. And the "Indian" of Da-song's games, a figure the settler imagination long placed at the boundary of the human, will return in feathers at the climax.

The bestiary is exhaustive by design. Every human in the film is at some moment assigned an animal relation, and the human appears only as what remains when the bestiary has been exhausted: the creature that can be insulted by all these names because it is none of them. This residual humanity, unprotected by any category, is the subject of Chapter 7.

CHAPTER THREE

3

Vertical Ontology

Stairs, Glass, Gravity, and the Bunker

3.1
The Staircase Film

Bong has described *Parasite* in interviews as a film of stairs, and the description is exact. The film contains at least four orders of staircase: the interior stair rising from the Park living room to the private bedrooms; the descent from the kitchen to the pantry; the hidden passage behind the pantry shelving that leads to the bunker; and the vast exterior system of steps, underpasses, and alleys down which the Kims flee through the rain to their flooded neighborhood. Each is a threshold that regulates who may be where, and each becomes, at the climax, a site of violence.

The staircase has a long career in the cinema of class. Eisenstein's Odessa Steps sequence in *Battleship Potemkin* (1925) made the stair the scene of massacre, bodies tumbling down a gradient engineered by power. Hitchcock's houses distribute their secrets vertically: the uranium hidden in wine bottles in the cellar of *Notorious* (1946), the corpse in the fruit cellar of *Psycho* (1960). Kim Ki-young's *The Housemaid* turned the new two-story house into a machine of class anxiety in which a child dies on the stairs, and Losey's *The Servant* measured the inversion of master and man by who ascends and who descends. In Benjamin's terms, the staircase is a dialectical image, a single form in which up and down, aspiration and fall, are simultaneously present.

3.2

Cellar and Attic

Gaston Bachelard's *The Poetics of Space* (1958) proposed that the house is organized by a fundamental vertical polarity. The attic is the zone of rationality, where the mind surveys its fears in the clear light of day; the cellar is the "dark entity" of the house, where fears are subterranean and irrational, and where one descends holding a candle. Bachelard lamented that the modern city apartment, lacking both, has lost its oneiric verticality. The Park house is a stranger case: a house with no attic at all, composed entirely of daylight and of a cellar beneath the cellar. Rationality has been redistributed onto the horizontal surfaces of a sunlit modernism, and the irrational has been buried two levels down.

Freud's essay "The Uncanny" (1919) observes that *heimlich*, homely, slides by its own semantic logic into its apparent opposite: the homely is also what is concealed, kept out of sight, secret. The *unheimlich* is that which ought to have remained hidden but has come to light. The bunker is the house's *heimlich* in this double sense, the most intimate and most secret part of the home, and Geun-sae's emergence is uncanny in the strictest Freudian definition. Anthony Vidler's *The Architectural Uncanny* (1992) traced the trope through modern architecture; the feminist tradition had already given it a female face. In Charlotte Perkins Gilman's "The Yellow Wall-Paper" (1892), a woman confined by her physician husband perceives another woman creeping behind the pattern of the wall. In Perrault's "Bluebeard" (1697) the forbidden chamber holds the bodies of the wives Bluebeard himself has murdered. The Park bunker, hidden behind pantry shelving, holds the residue of the house's previous regime: the husband of the previous housekeeper, kept alive by her stolen care. The inversion is exact: no master has killed anyone here, and the confinement is the work of the house's economy, not of a murderer's will.

3.3

The Glass Case

Walter Benjamin described the bourgeois interior of the nineteenth century as an *étui*, a velvet-lined case in which the private individual leaves the imprint of his existence, insulated from the world of commerce outside (*Arcades Project*, "Louis-Philippe, or the Interior"). In "Experience and Poverty" (1933) he welcomed the modernist architecture of glass, following Paul Scheerbart's *Glasar-*

chitektur (1914), as the enemy of traces, secrets, and possession: one cannot leave marks on glass. The Park house belongs to this second dispensation. Its defining feature is the enormous horizontal window that dissolves the boundary between living room and garden.

Yet the history of glass architecture already contains the film's secret. Philip Johnson's Glass House (1949) in New Canaan is famously paired with a nearly windowless Brick House that contained the guest quarters, a bathroom, and the mechanical plant serving the transparent pavilion. The transparent house is unthinkable without its opaque servant. Mies van der Rohe's Farnsworth House (1951) produced a different lesson: its client, the physician Edith Farnsworth, came to experience its total transparency as exposure and quarreled bitterly with the architect in court. A woman living alone in a glass box discovered that transparency is a privilege of the one who looks, not of the one who is seen. The Park house fuses both lessons: transparency above, opacity below; the luminous pavilion and, beneath it, the brick house turned bunker.

Adorno, writing in exile, concluded in *Minima Moralia* (1951) that dwelling in the traditional sense had become impossible, and that it belongs to morality not to be at home in one's home. His most famous sentence follows: wrong life cannot be lived rightly (*Es gibt kein richtiges Leben im falschen*). Heidegger, in "Building Dwelling Thinking" (1951), insisted that the real plight of dwelling lay not in the postwar housing shortage but in mortals' need ever anew to learn to dwell. *Parasite* refutes Heidegger by literalization. The housing shortage is not secondary to the plight of dwelling; it is the plight of dwelling, distributed by class. Lukács's celebrated phrase for the condition of the novel, "transcendental homelessness" (*The Theory of the Novel*, 1916), returns in the film as plain homelessness: a family sleeping on a gymnasium floor after the flood.

3.4

Topographies of Invisibility

In *The Condition of the Working Class in England* (1845), Engels described the urban design of Manchester as a machine of non-seeing. The commercial core and the bourgeois villas on the hills were connected by thoroughfares lined with shops, so that the wealthy could travel daily between home and office without ever glimpsing the working-class districts behind the façades. Fanon described the colonial city in *The Wretched of the Earth* (1961) as a world "cut in two": the settlers' town brightly lit, paved, and well fed; the native town crouched, hun-

gry, and dark. Lefebvre's *The Production of Space* (1974) generalized the insight: space is not a container of social relations but their product and instrument.

The film obeys Engels's rule with rigor. No member of the Park family ever descends into the Kims' neighborhood; the camera follows the Kims down, never the Parks. The Park house, walled and gated on its hill, is invisible from below, and the Kims' alley is invisible from above. The only mediators between the two worlds are the car, which carries Ki-taek up and down in the service of others, and the stairs, which the Kims traverse on foot. David Harvey's concept of accumulation by dispossession (*The New Imperialism*, 2003) and his account of the right to the city (2008) name the economic logic of this topography: the hill is a form of capital, and elevation is a return on it.

3.5

The Hydraulics of Class

If the film has a physics, it is gravity. Everything in it flows downward: rain, sewage, leftovers, contempt, the Kims themselves. The great storm is a single meteorological event lived as two weathers. For Yeon-kyo it is a blessing: it cancels a camping trip, scrubs the city's air of fine dust (미세먼지), and inspires an impromptu garden party under a blue sky. For the Kims it is catastrophe. They descend through the rain down stair after stair and tunnel after tunnel, the water running with them, to find their semi-basement filling with sewage. Ki-jung, perched on the lid of the elevated toilet as it geysers black water, lights a cigarette with sovereign composure. The toilet, raised near the ceiling because of the plumbing gradient, is the highest point in the Kims' home: their throne is their drain.

Mikhail Bakhtin's *Rabelais and His World* (1965) named this inversion the *material bodily lower stratum*: the carnivalesque logic by which the high is brought low through the body's excretory and generative functions, a degradation that is also renewal. Bong's flood is carnival without renewal. Victor Hugo, in the sewer chapters of *Les Misérables* (1862), called the sewer the conscience of the city, the place where every falsehood is stripped away and everything converges. In *Parasite* the city's conscience comes up through the Kims' toilet. Lang's *Metropolis* had already imagined the flood of the workers' city; Steinbeck's *The Grapes of Wrath* (1939) ended in a flood whose single image of grace, a woman nursing a starving stranger, the film conspicuously refuses (Chapter 7). Rob Nixon's *Slow Violence and the Environmentalism of the Poor* (2011) sup-

plies the contemporary frame: environmental harm is distributed by class, and climate arrives first in the basements.

Only a few things in the film travel upward. Labor ascends the hill each morning. Light signals ascend the bunker stairs. And smell, alone among the film's material agents, rises of its own accord, diffusing upward against the gradient that governs everything else. Odor is the one emanation of the basement that obeys no line. Chapter 4 makes this exception the key to the film.

3.6
The Two Windows

Leon Battista Alberti's *De pictura* (1435) founded the Western regime of perspectival representation on a metaphor: the picture is an open window through which the subject is seen. The film has two Albertian windows. The Parks' is a wide horizontal pane, reportedly proportioned by the production team to echo the film's own widescreen frame, through which a manicured lawn and a single tree present themselves as a landscape painting. The Kims' window is set at street level, so that it frames ankles, tires, a fumigation truck, and a drunk urinating against the wall. Perspective is a class position. The Parks look out across; the Kims look up from below the feet of passersby.

The film opens with a shot of socks drying on a rack in the Kims' window before the camera tilts down to Ki-woo, and it closes on the same window as snow falls past it. Its first and last images are thus framed by the lower window, not the upper one: the film's own point of view is lodged in the semi-basement, looking up. Chapter 8 returns to the implication: the Park window is a cinema screen, and the spectator, behind glass, sees without smelling.

3.7
From Tunnel to Bunker

The Western imagination of the subterranean has long figured the underground as a passage of hidden historical work. In *Hamlet* the ghost of the murdered king shifts beneath the stage, and Hamlet addresses him as "old mole," the fellow "in the cellarage." Hegel took up the image in his *Lectures on the History of Philosophy* to describe Spirit burrowing beneath the surface of history until it breaks through. Marx secularized it in *The Eighteenth Brumaire* (1852): the revolution, he wrote, does its work methodically underground, until Europe will leap up and exclaim, "Well grubbed, old mole!" Georges

Bataille, in his essay "The 'Old Mole' and the Prefix *Sur*" (c. 1930), set Marx's mole against the Icarian eagle of idealism and surrealism: base materialism burrows, it does not soar. Derrida's *Specters of Marx* (1993) brought the lineage full circle, reading the opening of the *Communist Manifesto*, the specter haunting Europe, through Hamlet's ghost.

Geun-sae is the ghost in the cellarage. Da-song, aged seven, saw him rising from the basement at night to eat leftover birthday cake and took him for a ghost; the encounter precipitated a seizure and a trauma the family treats with art therapy. But the Korean underground carries a specific Cold War charge. Between 1974 and 1990 South Korea discovered four infiltration tunnels dug beneath the Demilitarized Zone by the North: the communist mole literalized in granite. The civil-defense shelter is an anti-mole architecture, built against the subterranean threat from the North. When Moon-gwang mimics the cadence of a North Korean television announcer and holds her phone aloft like a missile-launch button, the comedy carries this history. The bunker built to defend the house against the mole of communism now harbors a bankrupt castella franchisee.

The literary underground supplies the remaining coordinates. Dostoevsky's Underground Man (1864) compares himself to a mouse nursing its humiliation beneath the floor. Ralph Ellison's narrator in *Invisible Man* (1952) lives in a sealed basement lit by 1,369 bulbs burning on current stolen from Monopolated Light & Power, insisting that light confirms his reality. Richard Wright's "The Man Who Lived Underground," written in the early 1940s and published in full only in 2021, sends a fugitive into the sewers, from which he observes the world above. Geun-sae, too, lives by stolen light. Each evening, as Park Dong-ik climbs the stairs, he triggers the motion-sensor lamps with his forehead to illuminate the master's ascent, murmuring a single English word of devotion: "Respect!" Adam Smith had diagnosed exactly this disposition, the tendency to admire and almost to worship the rich, as the great and most universal cause of the corruption of our moral sentiments (*The Theory of Moral Sentiments*, I.iii.3.1, 1759).

Here the thesis of the bunkered mole comes into focus. A tunnel is a passage: it connects one surface to another and implies a future breakthrough. A bunker is a terminus: sealed, defensive, self-enclosed, it stores rather than transports. The underground in *Parasite* no longer leads anywhere. Zygmunt Bauman's *Wasted Lives* (2004) described the populations rendered superfluous by modernization as "human waste" requiring disposal or storage. The bunker is a stor-

age facility for wasted lives. The old mole no longer grubs toward the surface; it has become a lamplighter, signaling homage upward through the circuitry of the master's house. Marx's "Well grubbed, old mole!" has been replaced by "Respect!"

CHAPTER FOUR

4

Osmocracy

Smell, Disgust, and the Partition of the Sensible

4.1
The Hierarchy of the Senses

Western philosophy has ranked the senses, and smell has almost always come last. Plato's *Timaeus* observes that odors have no proper kinds or names, being distinguished only as pleasant or painful; they are half-formed, belonging to transitional states of matter. Aristotle's *De Anima* (II.9) concedes that human smell is inferior to that of many animals and that we perceive odors only indistinctly. For both, the cognitive senses are sight and hearing; smell is the sense of the body's proximity to matter.

Kant gave the hierarchy its most consequential modern formulation. In the *Anthropology from a Pragmatic Point of View* (1798) he called smell the most ungrateful and the most dispensable of the senses, a kind of taste at a distance, and judged it contrary to freedom: unlike sight, which one may avert, smell forces others to partake of what they would refuse, so that it is less sociable than taste. The point is decisive for this thesis. For the philosopher of autonomy, the smell of another is heteronomy incarnate, an imposition upon the self's sovereign boundary. Hegel completed the exclusion in his *Lectures on Aesthetics*: art addresses only the two "theoretical" senses, sight and hearing, because smell, taste, and touch relate to matter as such and consume or dissolve their objects.

Freud supplied the hierarchy with a phylogenetic myth. In two long footnotes to chapter IV of *Civilization and Its Discontents* (1930) he speculated that civilization began with an "organic repression": when the human ancestor raised itself from the ground and adopted an upright posture, olfactory stimuli were devalued and visual stimuli became dominant, exposing the genitals and initiating a chain that runs through shame to the family and culture. The fateful process of civilization, he suggests, began with uprightness. The hypothesis is scientifically speculative, but as a cultural myth it is exact, and it supplies this thesis with its central correspondence: *verticality is deodorization*. The bourgeois house on the hill is the upright posture realized in architecture, a dwelling of the eye, while the semi-basement places its inhabitants at the nose-level of the ground. The vertical order of the film is the vertical order of Freud's civilization.

There is one counter-tradition. Nietzsche boasted in *Ecce Homo* (1888) that his genius was in his nostrils (*Mein Genie ist in meinen Nüstern*): he was the first to experience lies as lies by smelling them out. In *Parasite* the Nietzschean nose belongs to a child. Da-song, the youngest and least socialized member of the household, is the only one who smells the truth that the adults' eyes and credentials conceal.

4.2
The Sensory History of Class

Alain Corbin's *The Foul and the Fragrant* (1982) reconstructed the olfactory revolution of eighteenth- and nineteenth-century France. As hygienists mapped the city's miasmas, the bourgeoisie developed a new olfactory vigilance: it deodorized its own bodies and interiors, abandoned heavy animal musks for light floral scents, and came to perceive the poor through their smell, the odor of crowded rooms, damp walls, sweat, and latrines. Deodorization became a mark of distinction, and the stench of the poor became a sign of their moral condition. Constance Classen, David Howes, and Anthony Synnott's *Aroma* (1994) generalized the finding: odor has served across cultures to mark and police the boundaries of the other.

Georg Simmel saw the political consequence in his "Excursus on the Sociology of the Senses" (1907). Many of the educated, he observed, might sacrifice comfort for ethical ideals of solidarity, but could not overcome the involuntary physical revulsion provoked by the smell of the worker; hence the social question is also a question of the nose. Smell, for Simmel, is the most dissociating

of senses, because unlike sight it cannot be closed off. George Orwell reached the same conclusion from the opposite class position in *The Road to Wigan Pier* (1937), where he wrote that the real secret of class distinctions in the West could be summed up in four frightful words: "The lower classes smell." No feeling of like or dislike, Orwell argued, is as fundamental as a physical one, and no ideology of equality survives the conviction that the other is physically repellent.

Norbert Elias's *The Civilizing Process* (1939) charted the advancing threshold of shame and repugnance by which bodily functions were removed behind the scenes of social life, a process that makes the visible proximity of another's body increasingly intolerable to the civilized. Mark M. Smith's *How Race Is Made* (2006) showed that white Southerners defended slavery and then segregation in part through sensory claims, above all the claim that Black people carried a distinctive, offensive odor, which was invoked to justify separate schools, transport, and housing. Martha Nussbaum's *Hiding from Humanity* (2004) provides the moral psychology: disgust is a projective emotion through which dominant groups attribute the properties of animality, sliminess, decay, and stench to subordinated groups (her examples include Jews, women, gay men, and India's Dalits), thereby securing their own fantasized distance from animality and mortality.

4.3

Disgust, Abjection, and Desire

Mary Douglas's *Purity and Danger* (1966) defined dirt as "matter out of place": not a substance but the by-product of a classificatory system, the residue of what violates its lines. Julia Kristeva's *Powers of Horror* (1980) named the *abject*: that which is neither subject nor object, which the subject must expel to constitute its boundaries, and which returns to threaten them. The corpse, for Kristeva, is the utmost of abjection, the body without soul that shows us what we permanently thrust aside in order to live. Sara Ahmed's *The Cultural Politics of Emotion* (2004) adds that disgust is performative: the utterance "that's disgusting" generates both the disgusting object and the elevated subject who recoils from it.

Peter Stallybrass and Allon White's *The Politics and Poetics of Transgression* (1986) identified the dialectic that governs the film's most notorious scene. The bourgeois subject, they argue, constituted itself by excluding the low as dirty and contaminating, yet the excluded low returned as an object of nostalgia, longing, and fascination; what is socially peripheral becomes symbolically cen-

tral. Hidden beneath the living-room coffee table, Ki-taek and his children listen as the Parks, on the sofa above them, discuss the driver's smell and the cheap underwear found in the car, and then have sex there, aroused by the cheap underwear and the scene they imagine took place in the back of the car. Expulsion and desire occur in the same breath. The low is despised and consumed, and the master's libido draws its charge from the class transgression his ethic forbids.

4.4

The Olfactory Sequence

The smell of the Kims is introduced, developed, and consummated through six stages that together compose a dramaturgy of the nose. The first is *detection*. Dasong, sniffing the new housekeeper and the new driver, announces that they smell the same. The child's observation is innocent and therefore lethal; the Kims' forgeries of identity are suddenly threatened by a sense their forgeries had not addressed.

The second is *diagnosis*. That night the Kims hold a conference on the problem. Ki-woo proposes switching soaps and detergents. Ki-jung corrects him: it is the smell of the semi-basement, and it will not leave them until they leave the semi-basement. Her diagnosis is environmental, not racial or hereditary. The odor is the dwelling deposited on the body.

The third is *classification*. Park Dong-ik, explaining his new driver to his wife, praises Ki-taek for never crossing the line, then qualifies the praise: his smell crosses it. He likens the odor to an old radish, to a rag being boiled; Yeon-kyo, who has not ridden the subway in years, recognizes it as the smell of people who ride the subway. A perception has become a taxonomy.

The fourth is *eroticization*, in the sofa scene already discussed. The fifth is *avoidance*. After the flood, Ki-taek drives Yeon-kyo through her party errands, and she lowers the window against the odor of a man whose home has just been inundated with sewage; Ki-taek sees the gesture in the mirror. The flood has intensified the smell exactly as it has intensified dispossession: the more abject the milieu, the more insistent its trace on the body.

The sixth is *abjection unto death*. In the garden, amid the carnage, Park demands his car keys to rush his convulsing son to hospital. The keys land beneath Geun-sae's body. Reaching for them, Park pinches his nose against the smell of the dead man. Ki-taek, kneeling beside his dying daughter, sees the gesture. He rises and kills his employer. The sequence moves from perception to

judgment, from judgment to desire, from desire to avoidance, and from avoidance, through the corpse that Kristeva calls the utmost of abjection, to death.

4.5

The Uncounterfeitable Credential

Pierre Bourdieu's *Distinction* (1979) argued that taste classifies, and that it classifies the classifier; class is inscribed in the body as *hexis*, a durable way of standing, speaking, eating, and moving that functions as the most indisputable materialization of class. Randall Collins's *The Credential Society* (1979) analyzed the inflation of educational credentials as a mechanism of closure rather than a measure of competence. The Kims attack closure at precisely this point. They forge a university certificate, assume English names, invent an American education for Ki-jung (memorized, absurdly, to the tune of the patriotic song "Dokdo Is Our Land"), print business cards for a fictitious premium housekeeping agency called "The Care," and master the comportment of service professionals. Every symbolic credential is counterfeitable.

What cannot be counterfeited is the body's secretion. Smell is habitus at the molecular level, a *chemical habitus* that registers not what one has learned but where one has lived. Ki-jung's diagnosis places the film in the lineage of naturalism, with its doctrine of the determining *milieu* that Hippolyte Taine formulated and Zola dramatized, but with a crucial correction: the milieu acts not through heredity but through dwelling. The trap is circular. To lose the smell one must leave the semi-basement; to leave the semi-basement one needs the money that the smell prevents one from keeping. The odor is therefore not merely a sign of class position but a mechanism of its reproduction, a sensory feedback loop that converts the conditions of poverty into the evidence that justifies it. In Aristotle's doctrine the natural slave was recognizable by a body fitted for necessary labor; in the osmocratic order the natural servant is recognizable by a body that smells of the conditions servitude imposes.

4.6

Double Olfaction

W. E. B. Du Bois described the condition of Black Americans as *double consciousness*: the sense of "always looking at one's self through the eyes of others" (*The Souls of Black Folk*, 1903). Frantz Fanon's *Black Skin, White Masks* (1952) dramatized the moment of its imposition: a white child sees him and cries out "Tiens,

un nègre !" (in the standard English translation, "Look, a Negro!"), then tells its mother it is frightened, and the cry seals him into a body overdetermined from without. Sartre's phenomenology of the look in *Being and Nothingness* (1943) gives the formal structure: the Other's gaze transforms me from a free subject into an object for another.

Parasite transposes the structure into the olfactory register, and the transposition intensifies it. Da-song is Fanon's child: the one who utters what the adults suppress, and whose utterance fixes the other in a body. But a look can be returned; one can meet the Other's gaze and constitute him in turn as object. A sniff cannot be returned. It does not even objectify the person; it apprehends a molecular emanation detached from any face. After overhearing the Parks, Ki-taek lifts his collar and sniffs himself, smelling his own body through the master's nose. I call this *double olfaction*: the internalization of the dominant sense of the dominated. Du Bois famously wrote that the problem of the twentieth century was "the problem of the color-line." The twenty-first century, in Bong's diagnosis, has an olfactory line, and Park's recurrent phrase about crossing the line names it.

4.7

Osmocracy Defined

Jacques Rancière defines politics as a reconfiguration of the *partition of the sensible* (*le partage du sensible*): the distribution of what is visible and invisible, audible and inaudible, sayable and unsayable, which determines who has a part in the common (*The Politics of Aesthetics*, 2000). In *Disagreement* (1995) he returns to the opening of Aristotle's *Politics*, which distinguishes *logos*, the speech by which humans deliberate about the just and the unjust, from *phōnē*, the mere voice by which animals signal pleasure and pain. Politics occurs when those who have no part force their noise to be heard as speech.

The Kims do not reach even the threshold of *phōnē*. They appear in the Park house as *osmē*, odor: a sensory register beneath voice. Speech can be answered; noise can at least be heard and potentially reinterpreted as speech. Smell can be neither answered nor refuted. It can only be ventilated, masked, or exterminated. The film's opening sequence is its osmocratic prologue: a municipal truck sprays insecticide down the street, and Ki-taek tells his family to leave the windows open, welcoming the poison as a free public service. The poor consent to their own fumigation. Foucault's biopolitics, the government of populations

as living matter, appears here in its most banal form, and Agamben's bare life in its most domestic.

The subaltern signals of the film confirm the diagnosis. Geun-sae's Morse messages, pounded out on the light switch, are read by the master as an electrical fault; within the house only the child, a Cub Scout, is equipped to recognize them as language. Spivak's question, "Can the subaltern speak?" (1988), receives a precise answer: the subaltern can flicker, and can smell, but neither registers as speech.

I can now define the concept. *Osmocracy* is a regime of domination in which, first, social rank is perceived through odor; second, odor is attributed to the dominated as a natural property although it is produced by the conditions of dwelling and labor assigned to them; third, the dominant secure their own immunity through deodorization, distance, and the delegation of embodiment; and fourth, the dominated are thereby denied access to the sensory register in which political claims can be made. In such a regime the line between classes is not drawn by law or argued in speech; it is felt in the nostrils, and it is felt as nature. What remains to the dominated when speech is impossible is the act without words. Chapter 6 analyzes that act. Chapter 5 first asks who, in the osmocratic household, is charged with the labor of deodorization.

CHAPTER FIVE

5

The Reproductive Host

Feminist Political Economy of the Park Household

5.1

The Deodorizing Class

The domestic worker's labor is, materially, the labor of deodorization: cleaning, laundering, cooking, airing, disposing of waste, removing from the household every trace of the body's metabolism. The osmocratic order rests on a contradiction at this point. The class charged with producing the odorless interior is the class perceived as odorous. Everett Hughes's concept of "dirty work" (1962) described the delegation of physically and morally polluting tasks to those whose status is thereby confirmed as low. Bridget Anderson's *Doing the Dirty Work?* (2000) sharpened the analysis: the employer of a domestic worker purchases not labor-power alone but *personhood*, a whole person whose subordination performs the employer's status. The domestic is not only paid to clean; she is paid to be the one who cleans.

Judith Rollins, a sociologist who worked as a domestic in Boston households for her study *Between Women* (1985), documented the maternalism, deference rituals, and studied invisibility through which employers treated domestics as non-persons, speaking freely in their presence as if they were absent. Evelyn Nakano Glenn's "From Servitude to Service Work" (1992) traced a racial division of reproductive labor in which the heavy, dirty work was assigned to women of color while the managerial and "spiritual" labor of the household was retained by white mistresses. The Park household reproduces this division

along class lines. Yeon-kyo retains the managerial labor of hiring, scheduling, and status display; the dirty work descends to the Kims.

5.2
Social Reproduction and Its Theorists

Mariarosa Dalla Costa and Selma James's *The Power of Women and the Subversion of the Community* (1972) argued that housework is not a private service but the production of labor-power, the commodity on which capital depends and for which it does not pay. Silvia Federici's *Wages Against Housework* (1975) turned the analysis into a demand: what capital calls love is unwaged work. Her *Caliban and the Witch* (2004) traced the origin of this arrangement to primitive accumulation, when the enclosure of the commons was accompanied by the subjugation of women's bodies and the reduction of reproductive labor to a natural resource. Maria Mies described the same process on a world scale as *housewifization*: the construction of women's labor, including home-based piecework, as supplementary and therefore cheap (*The Lace Makers of Narsapur*, 1982; *Patriarchy and Accumulation on a World Scale*, 1986).

The Kims' first appearance on screen is a scene of housewifized labor: the whole family folding pizza boxes at piece rates on the floor of their home. Angela Davis's *Women, Race & Class* (1981) insisted that any adequate theory of housework must begin from the working-class women, disproportionately Black, who performed it for wages in other women's houses while performing it unwaged in their own. Tithi Bhattacharya's *Social Reproduction Theory* (2017) and Nancy Fraser's work on the crisis of care consolidated the framework this chapter applies: capitalism depends on life-making activities it simultaneously devalues and depletes.

5.3
Yeon-kyo: Status Production and Privileged Irresponsibility

Yeon-kyo has been read as the film's figure of bourgeois foolishness, repeatedly described in Konglish as "simple." A feminist reading must resist this. Veblen identified the wife of the leisure class as the ceremonial consumer of goods her husband produces, whose visible idleness is itself a form of service to his reputation. Hanna Papanek's concept of "family status production" (1979) named the work such women perform: managing children's education, hosting, networking, and curating the family's cultural capital. Sharon Hays's *The Cultural*

Contradictions of Motherhood (1996) described the ideology of "intensive mothering" that makes such women accountable for their children's psychological and educational outcomes. Korean education fever intensified this ideology into the figure of the manager mother whose information network is said to determine a child's future.

Yeon-kyo is a status producer whose entire labor is outsourced except the managing of the outsourcing. Her "belt of trust," the chain of personal recommendations through which she hires, is a feminine information network of the kind sociologists since Mark Granovetter (1973) have recognized as powerful, and the Kims exploit it precisely because it is her only instrument of control. Joan Tronto's *Moral Boundaries* (1993) provides the decisive concept: *privileged irresponsibility*, the capacity of the privileged to ignore their own dependence on care because others meet their needs without being seen. Yeon-kyo is not malicious. She is a manager who cannot perform the labor she manages and cannot see the workers who perform it, and her credulity is the structural blindness of the privileged, not a personal flaw.

5.4

Chung-sook: The Thrower

Chung-sook is a former national hammer-throw medalist, and her body is the most physically powerful in the film. Iris Marion Young's "Throwing Like a Girl" (1980) argued that feminine bodily comportment in patriarchal societies is characterized by inhibited intentionality and ambiguous transcendence: women are taught to experience their bodies as objects to be looked at rather than as instruments of action. Chung-sook's body is the refutation of this inhibition, a body of unified, projective force. Yet the society that once mobilized that body for national sporting glory has no use for it except in the kitchen. Simone de Beauvoir wrote in *The Second Sex* (1949) that few tasks resemble the torment of Sisyphus more than housework, an endless repetition that produces nothing durable and confines women to immanence while men pursue transcendence. Chung-sook's athletic transcendence has been converted into domestic immanence, and it returns only once, as violence: the kick that sends Moon-gwang down the stairs to her death.

The kick is preceded by the film's most consequential conversation between women. Moon-gwang appeals to Chung-sook as a fellow among the "needy neighbors" (불우이웃), the phrase of the year-end charity drive, asking for mercy on the basis of shared need. Chung-sook flatly refuses the designation.

Her refusal is not cruelty but misrecognition: she identifies upward, with the house she now runs, rather than laterally, with the woman she has displaced. Marx distinguished a class "in itself," constituted by objective position, from a class "for itself," conscious of its common interest (*The Poverty of Philosophy*, 1847). bell hooks argued in *Feminist Theory: From Margin to Center* (1984) that sisterhood cannot be presupposed from shared oppression but must be built through political solidarity. In *Parasite* sisterhood fails not across class but within it, under the pressure of competition for a single position in a single household. The reserve army turns sister against sister.

5.5

Moon-gwang: The Hidden Host

Moon-gwang is the thesis's central figure. For four years she has carried food from the Park refrigerator down to the husband concealed beneath the house, sustaining a body the market has expelled. Her labor is social reproduction in its purest and most hidden form: unpaid, invisible, performed out of love, and indispensable to a life no one else acknowledges. She is the host on whom Geun-sae lives, and the guest whose care the Parks unknowingly underwrite. Yet her gift is necessarily stolen. Derrida argued in *Given Time* (1991) that the pure gift is impossible, since any gift recognized as such enters a circuit of exchange and debt. Moon-gwang's gift escapes exchange only by passing through theft. In the osmocratic order even love must be parasitic in order to exist.

Eva Feder Kittay's *Love's Labor* (1999) named such care *dependency work* and argued that a just society owes support to those who perform it. Moon-gwang receives the opposite. She is killed by another woman's kick, dies of a head injury in the bunker, and leaves no public trace. Judith Butler's *Precarious Life* (2004) and *Frames of War* (2009) asked whose lives are grievable, whose deaths are recognized as losses. Park Dong-ik's death is news. Moon-gwang's is not even a statistic.

The feminist literary tradition supplies her ancestors. In *Jane Eyre* (1847), Grace Poole is the servant paid to keep Bertha Mason hidden in Thornfield's attic; Moon-gwang keeps her husband hidden out of love and against the master's will. Mrs. Danvers in Daphne du Maurier's *Rebecca* (1938) is the housekeeper loyal to the house's previous regime; Moon-gwang, who served the architect and passed to the Parks with the property, is loyal to the house itself. Toni Morrison's *The Bluest Eye* (1970) offers the most devastating parallel: Pauline Breedlove, the Fisher family's "ideal servant," finds in their orderly

white kitchen the beauty denied her own home, and slaps her daughter Pecola for spilling a cobbler there while comforting the employer's child. The servant who loves the master's house more than her own is a figure of alienation that only a feminist and antiracist criticism has been able to name.

Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar's *The Madwoman in the Attic* (1979) read Bertha Mason as the heroine's dark double, the rage the Victorian woman could not express. Gayatri Spivak's "Three Women's Texts and a Critique of Imperialism" (1985) read her as the colonial Creole sacrificed so that the English heroine might achieve individualism. Geun-sae is the madman in the basement. The Victorian house hid a colonial woman above; the Korean neoliberal house hides an indebted man below. Gender and verticality are inverted, but the structure persists: the house's respectability depends on a confined figure whose eruption destroys it, by fire at Thornfield, by knife at the Park villa.

5.6

Ki-jung: Judith Shakespeare's Sister

Virginia Woolf argued in *A Room of One's Own* (1929) that a woman must have money and a room of her own if she is to write fiction, and imagined Shakespeare's equally gifted sister, Judith, who runs away to London, is taken in by the actor-manager Nick Greene, becomes pregnant by him, and kills herself: in Woolf's parable a woman's genius, without money or a room, is destroyed through sexual and economic dependence on a man. Ki-jung is the most gifted member of her family. She forges the certificate, improvises an entire therapeutic persona from internet research, and conceives the stratagem that removes the chauffeur. She has neither money nor a room. She dies, and the less gifted brother survives to make plans.

Her persona as Jessica places her in what Eva Illouz calls *emotional capitalism* (*Cold Intimacies*, 2007), the fusion of therapeutic and economic discourse in which the psyche becomes a field of expertise and consumption. Arlie Hochschild's *The Managed Heart* (1983) defined emotional labor as the commercial management of feeling. Ki-jung sells simulated expertise in the psyche of a rich child, in a line that runs back, by the homophony traced in Chapter 1, to the *kisaeng* who sold cultivated art to the elite.

Her most effective credential, however, is her own underwear. To remove the chauffeur, she slips off her panties in the back seat of the car and leaves them where the master will find them. Carole Pateman's *The Sexual Contract* (1988) argued that the employment contract inherits the old law of master and

servant, and that the social contract presupposes a prior sexual contract establishing men's access to women's bodies. Ki-jung exploits that prior contract: she knows the master will read class transgression through sex, and she supplies the evidence. The gesture is at once a feat of agency and an act of self-objectification, a weaponization of the bourgeois sexual imaginary that only a woman of her class position could perform. She is stabbed carrying a birthday cake, the emblem of celebratory domestic labor, at the party she was hired to adorn.

5.7

The Feminization of Labor

In "A Cyborg Manifesto" (1985), Donna Haraway described a "homework economy" in which work is redefined as both literally female and feminized, whoever performs it. To be feminized, she wrote, means to be made extremely vulnerable, able to be disassembled, reassembled, and exploited as a reserve labor force. Guy Standing's "Global Feminization through Flexible Labor" (1989) and Cristina Morini's analysis of cognitive capitalism (2007) extended the thesis. *Parasite* depicts the feminization of an entire family. Ki-woo is a male governess, in M. Jeanne Peterson's sense of a figure of "status incongruence," neither servant nor family (1970). His plan to marry Da-hye when she enters university is the Austenian marriage plot, historically the only route of mobility open to women, assigned to a young man. At the party he asks Da-hye whether he fits in, the governess's question.

Ki-taek's feminization is more brutal. The father of the Kim family, once a small entrepreneur, is reduced to an employee who can be required to wear a feathered headdress for the employer's son's birthday game. When he ventures beyond his script, asking whether his employer loves his wife, or balking at the costume, Park's face hardens into the reminder that this, too, is paid work. Anderson's analysis of personhood is confirmed: the employer has bought the person, and the person includes his dignity.

5.8

Comparative Feminist Cinema

Chantal Akerman's *Jeanne Dielman, 23 quai du Commerce, 1080 Bruxelles* (1975) records, in near-real time, three days in the life of a widow who keeps house for her teenage son and supports them both by receiving a different man for paid

sex each afternoon, an appointment scheduled between peeling potatoes and setting the table; when the routine is disturbed, she kills one of these clients with scissors. Akerman's duration made reproductive labor, paid sex included, visible as labor; Bong's montage compresses it into the mechanics of the con. Both films end in an abrupt stabbing that erupts from a perturbed order of domestic work. Anna Muylaert's *The Second Mother* (2015) follows Val, a live-in nanny who raised her employers' son while her own daughter, Jéssica, grew up with relatives far away. When Jéssica arrives in São Paulo to sit the university entrance examination, she refuses the house's invisible lines, swimming in the pool and eating the son's reserved ice cream, and passes the architecture exam the son fails. The coincidence of names is uncanny: the Brazilian Jéssica crosses the line openly; the Korean "Jessica" crosses it by forgery and dies.

Alfonso Cuarón's *Roma* (2018), released in the same award season, ends with its Indigenous domestic, Cleo, climbing to the rooftop servants' quarters with the laundry after the family has declared its love for her. The two films propose rival architectures of servitude: the Mexican rooftop and the Korean basement, the affectionate embrace and the involuntary recoil. Ousmane Sembène's *Black Girl* (1966) follows Diouana, a young Senegalese woman hired in Dakar as a nanny and brought to Antibes, where her French employers make her their maid and keep her confined to the apartment; the African mask she gave them hangs there as décor, a prefiguration of the Park family's "Indian" props. Isolated, she dies by suicide in their bathroom. Against Kathryn Stockett's *The Help* (2009), criticized by historians for narrating Black domestic workers through a white heroine's liberal voice-giving, Bong refuses every mediating sympathetic consciousness.

The Korean feminist context completes the picture. *Parasite* appeared in the same year as the film adaptation of Cho Nam-joo's novel *Kim Ji-young, Born 1982* (2016), which dramatized the invisibility of women's domestic labor and became the emblem of a feminist upsurge that followed the killing in May 2016 of a 23-year-old woman by a man who waited in a restroom near Gangnam Station and told police he had acted because women ignored him, and the Korean #MeToo movement of 2018. Bong's women are not that movement's subjects, but they are its context: four women in four class positions, each defined by her relation to reproductive labor, none a villain.

5.9

The Reproductive Host Defined

The argument of this chapter can now be stated as a thesis. The cascade of parasites that Serres describes, and that the film dramatizes, rests on a host that is not the Park fortune but social reproduction: the feeding, cleaning, caring, and deodorizing that keep every body in the film alive. This host is gendered at its root, in the historical assignment of reproductive labor to women, and generalizes as feminization across the entire Kim family. It is rendered subterranean, located in kitchens, pantries, and bunkers. And it is subject to a constitutive misrecognition: in the osmocratic order the host must be perceived as the parasite. Those who absorb the body's burden on behalf of others are assigned the body's stigma. *Parasite* is not a film about parasites. It is a film about hosts who are not permitted to know that they are hosts.

CHAPTER SIX

6

The Sacrificial Feast

Mimesis, Expenditure, and the Knife

6.1

Decalcomania and the Monstrous Double

René Girard's *Deceit, Desire and the Novel* (1961) argued that human desire is mimetic: we desire not objects but what our models desire, so that every desire is triangular. The Kims desire the Parks' life by imitation. On the night of the storm they lounge in the living room imagining themselves its owners; Ki-woo rehearses a future as Da-hye's husband; Ki-taek wonders aloud where the Parks might be camping in the rain. Rousseau had already located the origin of inequality in *amour-propre*, the desire to be esteemed that arises when humans begin to compare themselves (*Discourse on Inequality*, 1755). The Kims' entire enterprise is driven by comparison, and its symptom is Ki-woo's question at the party: whether he fits in.

In *Violence and the Sacred* (1972), Girard showed that mimetic rivalry, as it intensifies, erases the differences between rivals until they become *monstrous doubles*, each the mirror of the other's violence. The Kims and the couple in the bunker are rivals for one object, the house, and the fight that erupts on the basement stairs is a struggle between doubles: two families of the same class, each threatening to expose the other to the same master. The working title *Decalcomania* names this logic. The mirror image is not only between rich and poor but within the poor, and the crisis of the film is the moment the two reflections collide.

Sartre gave the struggle its ontology in the *Critique of Dialectical Reason* (1960). Under conditions of scarcity, he argued, each person appears to the other as a potential consumer of what one needs to survive; the Other becomes the "counter-man," an intelligent, carnivorous species bent on our destruction, and that species is humanity itself as perceived through scarcity. The bunker fight is scarcity's phenomenology. Sartre also distinguished the *series*, people aligned side by side without common action, like strangers waiting for a bus, from the *group-in-fusion*, a collectivity formed in shared action. The evacuees sleeping on the gymnasium floor after the flood are a series: each family alone in the same catastrophe. No group-in-fusion forms. Fanon observed that the colonized, before turning on the colonizer, first discharge on one another the aggression deposited in their bodies (*The Wretched of the Earth*, 1961). *Parasite*'s violence obeys this sequence.

6.2
The Party as Potlatch

Marcel Mauss's *The Gift* (1925) analyzed the potlatch, the competitive feast in which status is established through lavish expenditure and even destruction of wealth. Georges Bataille's *The Accursed Share* (1949) generalized the insight into a "general economy": every system produces a surplus of energy that cannot be reinvested in growth and must be spent, either gloriously, in luxury, festival, and sacrifice, or catastrophically, in war. The garden party that Yeon-kyo improvises on the morning after the flood is an act of glorious expenditure: guests in summer clothes, premium beef, a manicured lawn under a sky the storm has scrubbed clean, a birthday cake for a child who already has everything.

The party is the point at which the accursed share returns. The surplus the household has accumulated, including the surplus humanity stored in its basement, is expended at once, and it is expended catastrophically, as blood on the lawn. Bataille's thesis that unspent surplus erupts as violence finds its domestic form: the house has stored more than it can contain.

6.3
Cowboys and Indians

Da-song is obsessed with a Hollywood image of Native Americans. He shoots toy arrows, wears feathers, and sleeps in his teepee in the garden during the storm while his parents watch from the sofa. Park remarks that the tent, bought

from the United States, will not leak. The detail is merciless: the dwelling of peoples whom the United States and its settlers dispossessed by war, forced removal (the Indian Removal Act of 1830 and the Trail of Tears), massacre (Sand Creek in 1864, Wounded Knee in 1890), and boarding schools built to erase their languages and cultures has become a waterproof commodity for a rich child, while the Kims' actual home floods. Cowboys and Indians rehearses that conquest as a game, and the Korean bourgeoisie, educated in American cultural capital, plays it in its own garden.

The party's centerpiece is a staged ambush in Da-song's game, for which Park and Ki-taek don feathered headdresses to play the attacking "Indians." The scripted violence never takes place. Before it can begin, real violence emerges from the basement: Geun-sae, having discovered his wife's death, comes up with a kitchen knife. Jean Baudrillard's account of simulation (*Simulacra and Simulation*, 1981) describes a hyperreal order in which images of violence have replaced violence; the film stages the collapse of that order, as the real breaks through the simulacrum from below. And Ki-taek kills his employer still wearing the headdress of the game. The costumed "Indian" kills the "cowboy." The colonial repressed of the game returns, displaced onto a Korean chauffeur and a Korean executive, in an act that no party to it understands in these terms.

Ousmane Sembène's *Black Girl* (1966) staged a comparable return: after Diouana's death, her employer carries her suitcase and the mask back to her mother in Dakar, who refuses his money, and a boy wearing the mask follows him out of the neighborhood. The Korean case adds a further layer. South Korea's modernity was forged under American hegemony; Bong's *The Host* had made the US military the source of its monster. In *Parasite* the American imaginary is internalized by the Korean elite as play, and the play becomes the costume of murder. On the soundtrack during the party plays Gianni Morandi's 1964 song "In ginocchio da te": on my knees to you. The title names the posture of supplication from which Ki-taek rises.

6.4

Carnival Without Regeneration

Bakhtin described the carnival as a festival of reversal in which a mock king is crowned and uncrowned, hierarchy is suspended, and the people experience their collective, regenerating body. The degradation of carnival is always ambivalent: it brings the high low in order to renew. The Park party is a carnival

in costume, complete with feathers and a staged insurrection, but its reversals are real and renew nothing. The king is uncrowned by death. Yet no people's body emerges, no world is turned upside down, and the morning after brings only police, courtrooms, and a property sale. The house passes to a German family. The structure that produced the catastrophe survives it intact.

6.5

Parricide Without Covenant

In *Totem and Taboo* (1913), Freud proposed a myth of origin: the brothers of the primal horde killed and devoured the father who monopolized the women, then, overcome by remorse, instituted the totem and the incest prohibition. Law is born of a parricide and the guilt that follows it, and its founding ritual is the totem meal. The birthday party is a feast at which the father of the household is killed. Park is the figure of symbolic law in the film: his recurrent concern with lines that must not be crossed makes him the bearer of what Lacan called the paternal "No," the prohibition that structures the symbolic order. Geun-sae's devotion to him is quasi-filial.

But the Freudian sequel does not occur. The brothers who might have formed a covenant have already destroyed one another: Moon-gwang killed by Chung-sook, Ki-jung by Geun-sae, Geun-sae by Chung-sook's skewer. No fraternal pact, no new law, no totemic remembrance follows the killing of the father. The law that arrives is the police. *Parasite* is a parricide without covenant: the founding crime of political order performed under conditions in which it can found nothing.

6.6

The Knife: Passage à l'acte

Lacan distinguished, in his seminar on anxiety (1962–63), between *acting out* and *passage à l'acte*. Acting out is a staging addressed to the Other, a message in the form of behavior that demands interpretation. *Passage à l'acte* is an exit from the scene altogether: the subject drops out of the symbolic frame and falls, identifying with the object as waste. Ki-taek's killing of Park is a *passage à l'acte* in the strictest sense. It addresses no one. It articulates no grievance. It is a rising and a striking, without preparation or speech, and its sequel confirms the structure: Ki-taek vanishes from the world, descending into the bunker to take

Geun-sae's place as the house's next ghost. He becomes the waste he struck to defend.

Walter Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" (1921) distinguished mythic violence, which posits and preserves law, from divine violence, which destroys law and, in Benjamin's enigmatic formula, is lethal without spilling blood. Ki-taek's violence is neither: it posits nothing, preserves nothing, and is bloody. Slavoj Žižek's *Violence* (2008) read the 2005 riots in the French *banlieues* as an outburst without program, a demand for visibility from those whom the order had rendered invisible. Fanon's theory of violence, by contrast, imagined it as collective, purifying, and constitutive of a new subject. Ki-taek's act is solitary and sterile. It transforms no one, including himself.

The literary analogues share its muteness. Zola's Bonnemort strangles the rentier's daughter during a charitable visit without a word of explanation. Akerman's Jeanne Dielman stabs her client with scissors after an afternoon in which nothing has been said. Chabrol's women shoot the family as it listens to Mozart. What, then, does Ki-taek's act defend? The precise trigger matters. Park pinches his nose not at Ki-taek but at the corpse of Geun-sae, a stranger to Ki-taek, a rival, and the man who has just killed his daughter. Ki-taek rises not in defense of his class, his family, or his honor, but against a gesture of disgust directed at a dead body. The killing is the convulsive insistence that the corpse, too, was human, and that the master, too, is a body. It is a humanist claim made in the only register left to it, which is the anti-humanist register of violence. Chapter 7 develops this paradox.

6.7
Sacrifice Without Sacred

Girard's account of sacrifice holds that the mimetic crisis is resolved when the community unanimously turns its violence on a single victim, the scapegoat, whose death restores order and is retrospectively sacralized. Ki-jung, the innocent bearer of the birthday cake, occupies the position of the sacrificial victim. But her death produces no unanimity, restores no order, and generates no sacred. The news coverage of the "incident" replaces myth with spectacle. The community that might have been reconstituted around the victim does not exist.

The chapter's conclusion can be stated as a series of negations. The climax of *Parasite* is a parricide without covenant, a carnival without regeneration, a sacrifice without sacred, and a potlatch whose surplus is blood. Each of the

great anthropological schemes of social renewal through violence is invoked and then voided. What remains is the bare fact of bodies on a lawn, and a gesture of disgust that was the last thing one of them saw.

CHAPTER SEVEN

7

Humanism Under Pressure

Dignity, the Face, and the Nose

7.1 *The Ascending Humanisms*

The dominant traditions of Western humanism locate human dignity in faculties that elevate the human above the body. Pico della Mirandola's *Oration on the Dignity of Man* (1486) imagines God placing the human at the center of the world without a fixed place or form, free to sink to the level of the brutes or to rise to the angels: the human is a chameleon, dignified by self-fashioning. Kant's *Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals* (1785) holds that in the kingdom of ends everything has either a price or a dignity, and that rational nature, capable of autonomous self-legislation, has dignity beyond all price; hence the Formula of Humanity, never to treat humanity merely as a means. The young Marx's *Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts* (1844) grounded humanity in species-being, the free conscious activity that alienated labor perverts. Sartre's "Existentialism Is a Humanism" (1946) declared that existence precedes essence: the human is nothing other than what it makes of itself. Levinas's *Totality and Infinity* (1961) located the ethical in the face of the Other, whose nakedness addresses me with the command not to kill.

These humanisms differ profoundly, but they share a vector. Each ascends: toward freedom, reason, self-making, or the transcendence of the face. *Parasite* tests each against the bottom of the house.

7.2
The Chameleon as Commodity

The Kims are Pico's chameleons. They become tutor, art therapist, chauffeur, and housekeeper on demand, assuming each role with conviction and competence. In Pico's cosmology such plasticity was the mark of human dignity. In the economy the film depicts it is the mark of employability. Richard Sennett's *The Corrosion of Character* (1998) argued that flexible capitalism, by demanding infinite adaptability, erodes the narrative continuity on which character depends. Luc Boltanski and Ève Chiapello's *The New Spirit of Capitalism* (1999) described a "projective city" in which worth is measured by activity, adaptability, and the capacity to move from project to project through networks. The Kims are its exemplary citizens. The Renaissance dignity of self-fashioning has been converted into the servitude of the endlessly reassemblable worker that Haraway called feminized.

Sartre's formula is realized as fraud and then refuted by smell. The Kims make themselves what they choose to be, and existence precedes essence, until an essence returns through the nose. What defeats their project is facticity in its most stubborn form: the body's chemical record of where it has lived. The existentialist subject can choose its project; it cannot choose its odor.

7.3
Kant's Nose: Dignity, Immunity, and Autoimmunity

The film pressures Kant at two points. The first is instrumentalization. Every relation in the film treats humanity merely as a means. The Parks use the Kims as instruments of their comfort and status; the Kims use the Parks as instruments of their survival; Ki-woo plans to use Da-hye as an instrument of mobility. The Formula of Humanity is not violated by a villain; it is violated by a structure that leaves no one the option of honoring it.

The second is more intimate. Kant judged smell contrary to freedom because it imposes itself on others. For the autonomous subject, the other's odor is heteronomy: an assault on the self's sovereign boundary. The bourgeois ideal of autonomy thus contains an olfactory condition: the free subject must be immune to the bodies of others. Roberto Esposito's *Communitas* (1998) and *Immunitas* (2002) provide the decisive conceptual frame. Community derives from *munus*, a gift that is also an obligation and a burden; the members of a community are those bound by a shared debt. Immunity is exemption from the

munus: the immune are those released from the common obligation. The Park household is an immunitary apparatus in Esposito's strict sense. Its hill, gate, private car, deodorized interior, and delegated labor exempt its members from the common burden of being a body. *Vicarious corporeality* is immunization by purchase.

Esposito, following Derrida, insists that immunity tends toward *autoimmunity*: the protective system turns against the body it protects. The bunker is the house's autoimmune organ. Built as a shelter against an external threat, it incubates the agent of the household's destruction. The immunitary logic that delegates embodiment downward produces, at the bottom of the house, a concentration of abjected bodies that eventually erupts into the garden. The more perfect the immunity, the more lethal the autoimmune reaction.

7.4

The Grace That Does Not Come

The humanist novel of the nineteenth and twentieth centuries repeatedly resolved the problem of class through an act of grace. In *Les Misérables* the Bishop of Digne gives Jean Valjean the silver candlesticks he has been caught stealing, and the gift transforms the thief. In *Oliver Twist* (1837–39) the benevolent Mr. Brownlow rescues the orphan from Fagin's den and restores him to his rightful station. In *Bleak House* (1852–53) Dickens made the more radical argument that the rich cannot immunize themselves: the fever bred in the slum of Tom-all-Alone's travels through the crossing-sweeper Jo into the house of the respectable, so that contagion compels the recognition charity withholds. Steinbeck closed *The Grapes of Wrath* in a flooded barn where Rose of Sharon, having lost her child, nurses a starving stranger: humanity reconstituted at the level of the body itself.

Parasite forecloses each of these resolutions. There is no bishop: the rich in the film give nothing beyond wages. There is no Brownlow: no benevolent bourgeois intervenes. Dickens's contagion crosses the line as smell, but its crossing produces disgust rather than recognition. And the flood ends not with a woman nursing a stranger but with a gymnasium floor and a pile of donated clothing. I call this *the Brownlow foreclosure*: the deliberate refusal of the narrative mechanism by which humanist fiction reconciled the classes through individual virtue.

The contrast with Hirokazu Kore-eda's *Shoplifters*, which won the Palme d'Or the year before *Parasite*, is instructive. Kore-eda's family of petty thieves

is bound not by blood but by chosen care; its members steal to live but love freely. Bong's family is bound by blood but functions as a firm. Where Kore-eda finds a humanism of elective kinship beneath the law, Bong finds only an enterprise beneath the house. Lee Chang-dong's *Burning*, released the same year, offers a third model: an existential humanism of the dispossessed son whose rage against a rich man's indifference culminates, as in *Parasite*, in a killing, but whose interiority the film inhabits. Bong never grants Ki-taek that interiority. His act is opaque, which is to say structural.

Bertolt Brecht anticipated the film's moral premise. In *The Good Person of Szechwan* (1943), the prostitute Shen Te can sustain her goodness only by periodically disguising herself as a ruthless male cousin, Shui Ta; the gods who demand goodness provide no world in which it can survive. In *The Threepenny Opera* (1928) the principle is reduced to a couplet: *Erst kommt das Fressen, dann kommt die Moral*, first comes feeding, then morality. Chung-sook's retort that Yeon-kyo is kind because she is rich is Brecht's thesis in a single line of dialogue. Goodness is a luxury good.

7.5
The Verminous and the Invisible

Kafka's *The Metamorphosis* (1915) is the humanist text *Parasite* most fully inverts and completes. Gregor Samsa, the salesman whose wages support his family, awakens as monstrous vermin. The family, deprived of his income, takes in three lodgers and serves them, becoming servants in its own home; the lodgers recoil in disgust when they glimpse Gregor; his father bombards him with apples, one of which lodges in his back and festers. When Gregor dies, the family feels relief, and the story ends with the sister's blossoming. In *Parasite* the entire family is verminized, and the father's final fate is to become Gregor: hidden, nocturnal, eating scraps, lodged beneath the house, his existence a secret kept by his son.

Ralph Ellison's invisible man is invisible, he explains, simply because people refuse to see him. Adam Smith had already described the shame of the poor man who feels that his poverty "places him out of the sight of mankind" (*Theory of Moral Sentiments*, I.iii.2.1). Smith's same book contains his first use of the "invisible hand," by which the rich, consuming little more than the poor despite their rapacity, are led to distribute the necessaries of life nearly as if the earth had been divided equally (IV.1.10). The film literalizes the doctrine of trickle-

down with gravitational precision: the leftovers of the Park refrigerator descend the stairs to the bunker. The invisible hand feeds the invisible man.

In *The Wealth of Nations* (1776), Smith defined necessaries to include whatever custom renders it indecent for creditable people, even of the lowest order, to be without, and gave the example of the linen shirt, without which a day-laborer would be ashamed to appear in public. Amartya Sen made this the basis of his capabilities approach: among the basic capabilities is the ability to appear in public without shame (*Development as Freedom*, 1999). The Kims' smell is their missing linen shirt. It is the one deficit that renders them unable to appear without shame, and it cannot be purchased. Martha Nussbaum's list of central capabilities includes affiliation, the social basis of non-humiliation, and control over one's material environment, including property (*Women and Human Development*, 2000; *Creating Capabilities*, 2011). The osmocratic order denies both at once.

Two literary curiosities complete the olfactory humanism. In Gogol's "The Nose" (1836), a petty official's nose detaches itself and parades through Saint Petersburg in the uniform of a higher rank than its owner's: rank as an autonomous organ. In Patrick Süskind's *Perfume* (1985), Grenouille is born without a personal odor and is therefore not perceived as fully human by those around him. The film occupies the opposite pole: its poor have too much odor to be perceived as fully human.

7.6

The Critiques of Humanism

The twentieth century produced powerful critiques of humanism's exclusions, and the film belongs with them. Sylvia Wynter argued that Western modernity has produced successive "genres" of the human, culminating in the economic Man of bourgeois liberalism, whose overrepresentation as the human as such relegates the jobless, the homeless, and the poor to the status of a dysselected human Other ("Unsettling the Coloniality of Being/Power/Truth/Freedom," 2003). Fanon closed *The Wretched of the Earth* with a call for a new humanism to replace the one Europe had proclaimed while massacring. Simone Weil's "The Iliad, or the Poem of Force" (1940) showed that force turns a person into a thing, even before it kills; her factory journal recorded the affliction that makes the worker invisible, and she wrote that attention is the rarest and purest form of generosity. The Parks lack attention entirely. Moon-gwang possesses it in its purest form.

Arendt's analysis of labor as the activity bound to necessity, Butler's analysis of precarity and grievability, and Eric Santner's concept of *creaturely life* (2006), the human's exposure to the arbitrary violence of sovereign power, converge on a shared insight: what is most universal about human beings is not their capacity to transcend the body but their vulnerability as bodies. Edward Said's *Humanism and Democratic Criticism* (2004) and Paul Gilroy's "planetary humanism" (*Against Race*, 2000) sought to rescue humanism from its imperial history by grounding it in shared vulnerability rather than shared reason. This is the point of departure for infrahumanism.

7.7 *Infrahumanism*

I can now state the thesis's culminating proposal. *Infrahumanism* is a humanism constructed from below. It grounds human dignity not in the faculties that elevate us above the body but in the body that none can delegate without remainder. Its first principle is the shared condition of embodiment: gravity, fluids, odor, decay, and dependency are common to all, and no amount of wealth can make the rich less embodied, only less aware of their embodiment. Its second principle is the refusal of immunity. With Esposito, it treats the burden of being a body as a *munus*, a common obligation, and identifies the delegation of that burden through vicarious corporeality as the original injustice of the osmocratic order.

Its third principle is an ethics of proximity without disgust. Against Levinas, it holds that the face is not the only epiphany of the Other. The Other is also present when the face is absent: as smell, as residue, as the warmth left in a room, as the corpse. Levinas's face commands "thou shalt not kill." In the film, a gesture made with the master's face against the body of another, the nose-pinch, revokes that command, and the revocation is answered by killing. The lesson is that the command of the face extends to the body or does not hold at all. Infrahumanism begins from disgust, not by denying it, but by recognizing it as the threshold that ethical life must cross.

Its fourth principle draws on resources the ascending humanisms excluded: Bataille's base materialism, which refuses the elevation of spirit over matter; Bakhtin's lower bodily stratum, in which degradation is also renewal; Douglas's insight that dirt is a by-product of classification; and the feminist tradition, from Beauvoir to Grosz's *Volatile Bodies* (1994), that exposed the gendered assignment of embodiment to women. Its fifth principle is political. It

calls for the conversion of *osmē* into *logos*, making the claims of the bodily heard as speech; for the revaluation of the reproductive host; for a solidarity that is built rather than presumed; and for the reopening of the tunnel that the bunker has sealed.

The film does not affirm infrahumanism. It demonstrates its necessity negatively, in the manner Adorno prescribed for a philosophy that can glimpse right life only in the determinate negation of the wrong. Ki-taek's knife is infrahumanism's grotesque negative image: a defense of the corpse's humanity carried out by producing another corpse. Its terrible lesson is that where the body is not recognized as common ground, it returns as the ground of violence.

CHAPTER EIGHT

8

The Anosmic Screen

Genre, Form, Spectatorship, and Reception

8.1
A Comedy Without Clowns, a Tragedy Without Villains

Bong described *Parasite* as "a comedy without clowns, a tragedy without villains." The formula is a poetics. The film passes through caper, social satire, farce, home-invasion thriller, horror, melodrama, and tragedy, and ends in a fantasy that the final cut exposes as fantasy. Each genre is entered with full conviction and abandoned without warning. Bertolt Brecht's *Verfremdungseffekt* sought to interrupt the spectator's identification so that the social causes of suffering might become visible; Bong's tonal ruptures achieve a comparable estrangement without Brechtian didacticism. The spectator laughs at the con, then discovers that the laughter has made her complicit in a lateral war among the poor.

The absence of villains places the film in a precise relation to the theory of tragedy. For Hegel, tragedy stages the collision of two ethical powers, each justified within its own sphere, as Antigone's duty to her brother collides with Creon's duty to the city. Raymond Williams's *Modern Tragedy* (1966) argued that modern tragedy is the tragedy of ordinary people and of disorder as a permanent social condition, rather than of the fall of the great. *Parasite* is tragic in Williams's sense. Its catastrophe issues not from individual flaws but from a structure in which each party acts reasonably within its position. The Parks are polite; the Kims are resourceful; Moon-gwang is loving; the result is carnage.

The comedy, too, is turned against itself. Henri Bergson's *Laughter* (1900) defined the comic as something mechanical encrusted upon the living. After his head injury, Ki-woo laughs involuntarily, at his trial and in the face of the detectives, a neurological automatism quite literally encrusted on a living person. The film's comic register ends as a symptom: laughter detached from any joke, a body laughing at what is not funny. It is the most exact image the film offers of its own spectatorial effect.

8.2

Lines, Tilts, and Mirrors

Bong, nicknamed "Bong-tail" in the Korean press for his obsessive attention to detail, constructs the film's compositions as an argument. Members of the two families are repeatedly separated within the frame by architectural verticals: window mullions, door frames, the edge of a wall, the boundary between light and shadow. The line that Park speaks of is drawn by the camera before it is spoken. Vertical camera movements are reserved for thresholds: the opening tilt from the semi-basement window down to Ki-woo, the descent of the stairs into the bunker, the closing tilt that returns to the window as snow falls.

The sequence in which the Kims drive Moon-gwang from her post, using peach fuzz to trigger her allergy and hot sauce on a tissue to stage the coughing of blood, is cut as a bravura montage over a mock-Baroque score by Jung Jae-il. Labor appears here as choreography. The contrast with Akerman is formal and political. *Jeanne Dielman* makes domestic labor visible by refusing to cut it, compelling the spectator to endure its duration. Bong accelerates the labor of the con into spectacle and reserves duration for the hidden work of reproduction, which the film declines to show at all. Moon-gwang's four years of provisioning appear only as a fact recounted. The film's formal economy enacts its thesis: the reproductive host is the one thing the camera does not dwell upon.

A folkloric reading, offered as a resonance rather than an intention, deepens the peach sequence. In Korean custom peaches are traditionally excluded from the table of ancestral rites because they are believed to repel spirits. The fruit the Kims use to exorcize Moon-gwang from the house drives out the keeper of its ghost.

8.3

The Anosmic Screen

Hegel restricted art to the theoretical senses of sight and hearing. Cinema is their technological consummation, and it has never mastered smell. The attempts are instructive in their failure: AromaRama, which pumped scents into theaters for *Behind the Great Wall* (1959); Smell-O-Vision, which piped odors to individual seats for *Scent of Mystery* (1960); and John Waters's Odorama, the scratch-and-sniff cards distributed for *Polyester* (1981), whose camp vulgarity made the medium's olfactory impotence the joke. The cinema is, structurally, a deodorized interior.

Parasite makes the sense its medium cannot transmit into the decisive fact of its plot. Smell is rendered only through its effects: a child's sniffing, a conference about detergents, a husband's description, a window lowered, a collar lifted, a nose pinched. The spectator infers the odor without ever receiving it. Her position is therefore that of the Parks. She sees the Kims through a screen, hears them, judges them, and is immune to them. The great window of the Park living room, reportedly proportioned to echo the film's own widescreen frame, completes the identification: the spectator watches the garden through the Parks' glass.

This is the thesis of *anosmic spectatorship*. Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" (1975) showed that classical cinema organized the spectator's look according to sexual difference, aligning the camera's gaze with a male subject and positioning women as objects of looking. *Parasite* exposes a second structuring difference inscribed in the apparatus itself: the sensory selection of the screen reproduces class immunity. The film cannot overcome the spectator's anosmia, but it can make that anosmia perceptible as a privilege. Its wager is that a spectator made aware that she is watching from the Parks' sofa might feel her immunity as a form of complicity. The last Park is in the audience.

8.4

The Subtitle as Line

Accepting the Golden Globe for best foreign-language film in January 2020, Bong observed through his interpreter that once audiences overcome the one-inch-tall barrier of subtitles they will discover many more remarkable films. The subtitle is a line, and the reluctance of Anglophone audiences to cross it is the international form of Park's anxiety. The subtitles themselves, written by Darcy

Paquet, perform a translation that is also a class translation: Seoul National University becomes Oxford, *jjapaguri* becomes "ram-don," and Korean social markers are converted into globally legible equivalents. The film crossed the line by making its class codes portable.

Its portability was its argument. Bong remarked in interviews that, in a sense, all of us now live in a single country called capitalism. The film's reception confirmed the claim. Audiences from Brazil to France to the United States recognized their own cities in Seoul's verticality, and in a period of global housing crisis the semi-basement became a transnational figure.

8.5

Reception and Its Ironies

Parasite won the Palme d'Or in 2019, the first Korean film to do so, and in February 2020 won four Academy Awards, including best picture, the first film not in English to receive that award. Days later, at a campaign rally in Colorado Springs on 20 February 2020, President Donald Trump complained that a South Korean film had won, adding that the United States already had enough trouble with South Korea over trade, and asked whether *Gone with the Wind* could be brought back. The remark staged, with unwitting precision, the conflict the film dramatizes. *Gone with the Wind* (1939) romanticized a Georgia slave plantation and presented Mammy, a woman enslaved by the O'Hara family, as devoted to the family that owned her. Hattie McDaniel won the Academy Award for that role, the first Black performer to win one, and was seated apart from the film's white cast at the segregated ceremony. *Parasite* depicts waged servants whose loyalty is a performance and whose discontent is a structure. The call to restore one film in place of the other was, at the level of cultural fantasy, a call to restore the contented slave.

The film also generated a cycle of successors, often grouped under the slogan "eat the rich": Ruben Östlund's *Triangle of Sadness* (2022), in which a yacht's toilet manager becomes the captain of the castaways because only she can fish; Mark Mylod's *The Menu* (2022); Rian Johnson's *Glass Onion* (2022); Emerald Fennell's *Saltburn* (2023), in which an outsider infiltrates an aristocratic family and ends in sole possession of its house. Measured against *Parasite*, the cycle frequently restores what Bong removed: villainous rich people and cathartic revenge. *Saltburn* realizes, as fantasy, the "fundamental plan" that Ki-woo can only dream. In converting structure into spectacle and villainy, these films reveal by contrast the rigor of Bong's refusal.

8.6

Allegory and Its Discontents

Fredric Jameson called in *Postmodernism, or, The Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism* (1991) for an aesthetic of "cognitive mapping": representations that would allow individuals to situate themselves within the otherwise unrepresentable totality of global capital. The Park house is such a map, and its legibility explains the film's global reach. But the film also knows how maps are consumed. Ki-woo's reflex, pronouncing things "metaphorical," is the reflex of the aspiring bourgeois for whom the symbol is an object of cultural consumption, a scholar's stone to be admired on a shelf. The danger of allegory is that it can be enjoyed from above. A family like the Parks could watch *Parasite*, admire its metaphors, and return untroubled to a deodorized home.

Parasite is therefore a self-indicting allegory. It offers a cognitive map and simultaneously shows that maps can be possessed as ornaments. Its defense against its own consumption lies in what cannot be allegorized: the smell that has no meaning, only effects, and that the spectator cannot receive. Allegory translates the world into signs; odor resists translation. The infra-sensible is the film's guarantee against becoming, in its turn, a scholar's stone.

CONCLUSION

C

The Father in the Ground

C.1
The Final Images

The film ends twice. Its first ending is the aftermath of the massacre. Ki-woo wakes from brain surgery into a laughter he cannot govern. He and his mother stand trial for their part in the fraud. Ki-taek has vanished, the object of a manhunt, and the Park house is sold to a German family who know nothing of what lies beneath it. From a hillside above the neighborhood, Ki-woo watches the house and notices the lights on its stairs flickering in a pattern. It is Morse code, and it is his father. Ki-taek has descended into the bunker and taken Geun-sae's place; he creeps up at night for food, and each night he signals without knowing whether anyone will see.

The second ending is a reply. Ki-woo composes a letter announcing what he calls a fundamental plan: he will make money, a great deal of it, and buy the house, and on the day they move in his father need only walk up the stairs. The film stages the plan as if it had come true. Ki-woo, prosperous, waits in the sunlit garden; his father climbs out of the basement; they embrace. Then the image returns to Ki-woo in the semi-basement, writing, and the film closes on the window where it began, with snow falling past it. Between these endings Ki-woo has returned the scholar's stone to a stream. The letter in light, the fundamental plan, and the stone returned compose the film's final argument, and this conclusion reads them through the framework the thesis has built.

C.2

The Fundamental Plan

The word Ki-woo chooses is exact. A fundamental plan is a plan that aims at the foundation. In German, *Grund* names ground, foundation, and reason at once, and a *Grundstück* is a plot of land, a piece of real property. Leibniz's principle of sufficient reason, *nihil est sine ratione*, nothing is without ground, became for Heidegger in *The Principle of Reason* (*Der Satz vom Grund*, 1957) the governing demand of modernity that a reason be rendered for every being. Ki-woo's plan renders the principle literal and terrible. The son proposes to purchase the *Grundstück* in whose ground his father is buried alive. The foundation he hopes to own is the grave he hopes to open.

The plan is also arithmetically absurd, and the film knows it. Bong has remarked in interviews that, at an ordinary wage, the purchase would take centuries. Thomas Piketty's *Capital in the Twenty-First Century* (2013) explains why: when the rate of return on capital exceeds the rate of growth of output and income, inherited wealth and asset prices pull away from anything labor can earn, and real estate becomes the privileged form of patrimony. In Seoul, as in London or San Francisco, the house on the hill is not a reward for work but a return on ownership. A plan to buy it with wages is a plan to outrun r with g.

Bourdieu explains why such plans arise among those least able to realize them. In his Algerian fieldwork, published as *Algérie 60* (1977), and again in *Pascalian Meditations* (1997), he argued that a rational plan of life presupposes a minimal hold on the present. Those deprived of economic security cannot project themselves into a calculable future, and their aspirations, cut loose from their objective chances, oscillate between fatalism and fantasy. The film assigns the two poles to father and son. In the gymnasium shelter after the flood, Ki-taek delivers his sermon that the only plan that cannot fail is to have none: fatalism as the rationality of those who have no future. Ki-woo's fundamental plan is its inverse: a plan without means, a daydream written in the grammar of strategy.

Lauren Berlant's *Cruel Optimism* (2011) names the affective structure. An attachment is cruel when the object one desires is itself an obstacle to one's flourishing. The house is such an object. It is the source of the family's catastrophe and the shape of its hope, and the son's hope binds him to the structure that buried his father. The fantasy is rendered in the Park house's own aesthetic, sunlight on a lawn, because the dispossessed can imagine deliverance only in the image of the masters' comfort. Freud's "Family Romances" (1909)

described the child's fantasy of nobler parents. Ki-woo's is a family romance inverted: a fantasy of ennobling the father by buying him out of the ground.

Ernst Bloch distinguished abstract utopia, wishful thinking detached from the tendencies of the real, from concrete utopia, the anticipation of a not-yet latent in present possibilities (*The Principle of Hope*, 1954–59). The last word of Bloch's great work is *Heimat*, homeland: something that shines into everyone's childhood and in which no one has yet been. Ki-woo's house is *Heimat* converted into real estate, a home in which no member of his family has ever been except as servant or intruder. The film does not mock the dream. It shows, with great tenderness and no consolation, that the dream has been furnished by the order that forbids it.

C.3

The Stone and the Stream

The scholar's stone, a landscape stone (산수경석) of the kind prized by the Confucian literati as a mountain in miniature, arrives at the beginning of the film as a gift from Min, Ki-woo's well-born friend, with the promise that it brings material fortune. For the Kims it is a talisman of ascent: a portable mountain for a family that lives below the street. It is also the first object of the con. Ki-woo pronounces it metaphorical, carries it through the flood, and confesses afterward that it seems to cling to him. In one of the film's most enigmatic images it appears to rise toward him out of the floodwater, as though weightless: either a hallucination or a hint that the talisman, like every credential in the film, is counterfeit. It becomes, finally, the weapon with which Geun-sae smashes Ki-woo's skull.

Marx's analysis of commodity fetishism in the first chapter of *Capital* describes objects invested with powers that belong in fact to social relations. The stone is a fetish of exactly this kind: a lump of mineral endowed with the power to bring wealth, in a society where wealth is produced and distributed by relations no stone can alter. Its career in the film is the career of the fetish unmasked. It promises fortune, delivers catastrophe, and finally reveals itself as what it always was, a rock that can break a head.

Ki-woo returns it to a stream. The gesture admits several readings. It may be Camus's Sisyphus reversed: rather than pushing the rock eternally uphill, the son sets it down in moving water, declining the absurd labor Camus asked us to imagine as happy (*The Myth of Sisyphus*, 1942). It may be the Buddhist renunciation of attachment. It may be resignation. Whatever it signifies, it dif-

fers structurally from every other act in the film. Serres defined the parasitic relation as an arrow that takes without returning. The return of the stone is the film's only image of restitution: something given back with nothing taken. That its recipient is a stream rather than a person is the film's bleakest comment on its social world. Restitution is possible only to nature. The stream recalls the Ch'ŏnggye of Bong's grandfather's novel, along which Park Taewon's colonial poor lived their lives, and the stone, released, re-enters a circulation older than property.

C.4

The Letter in Light

Ki-taek's letters are written in light. Jacques Rancière's *The Nights of Labor* (1981) recovered the writings of nineteenth-century French workers who spent their nights composing poetry, philosophy, and letters, refusing the partition of time that assigned their nights to sleep and the restoration of labor-power. Their emancipation, Rancière argued, lay less in any program than in this refusal: the claim to a life of thought that the order of things denied them. Ki-taek in the bunker is a nocturnal writer in the most minimal form imaginable. He has no paper and no audience, only a light switch, the dark, and Morse code. Yet he writes.

The difference between the house's two lamplighters is the direction of address. Geun-sae signaled upward. His lights greeted the master, and his single word, "Respect!", was homage addressed to a man who never knew he existed. Ki-taek signals laterally, to his son, and he is read. Spivak's question whether the subaltern can speak turns, in her own argument, on whether anyone is positioned to hear. Within the house no one was; the master took the lights for an electrical fault. Outside it, on a hillside, there is a son. The subaltern's speech is illegible vertically and legible horizontally.

This is the one point at which the film permits something like hope, and it is carefully circumscribed. The light that was homage has become correspondence. The underground, sealed as a bunker, has opened a single channel, and the channel runs not upward to the master but across to kin. The correspondence remains asymmetrical: the son's reply is a letter the film never shows him sending. But it is the first exchange in the film that is neither parasitic nor transactional, the first message from below received as a message. Infrahumanism, which the film withholds as an ethic, appears here as a practice in miniature:

a body in the dark, making itself known by the only means it has, to someone who knows how to read it.

C.5

The Ghost Materialized

One comparison remains, because the ending completes it. Henry James's *The Turn of the Screw* (1898) installs a governess in a country house where she perceives the ghosts of two former servants, the valet Peter Quint and her predecessor Miss Jessel, whose liaison had crossed the line of class, and she becomes convinced that the children in her care see them too. Since Edmund Wilson's "The Ambiguity of Henry James" (1934), criticism has divided over whether the ghosts are real or the governess's projection. *Parasite* reproduces the configuration: tutors in the governess's position, a housekeeper who keeps the house's secrets, a child who has seen a ghost rise from below at night, and an apparition belonging to the servant class.

But Bong settles James's ambiguity on the side of matter. The ghost is a real man who ate real cake; the child really saw him; the haunting is a fact of the household economy. And the ending renews it. Ki-taek becomes the house's new ghost, and its new owners may one day have a child who sees him too. The specter that haunts the house is not a psychological projection but a social relation, and it reproduces itself as reliably as the house changes hands.

C.6

The Theses Restated

The argument can now be gathered. First, *Parasite* is an anatomy of *osmocracy*: a regime in which class is perceived through odor, odor is attributed to the dominated as nature although it is produced by their conditions, and the dominated are thereby denied the sensory register in which political claims can be made. Second, the regime rests on *vicarious corporeality*, the purchase of exemption from the body, which immunizes the rich and assigns to the poor the stigma of the animality they absorb. Third, beneath the film's cascade of parasites lies a *reproductive host*, the gendered labor of feeding, cleaning, and care, whose bearers are constitutively misrecognized as parasites. Fourth, the film records the closure of the underground as a space of history: the tunnel has become a bunker, and the old mole a lamplighter. Fifth, the cinematic apparatus, which cannot transmit smell, positions the spectator as the Parks, and the

film's form makes that immunity perceptible. Together these theses ground the proposal of *infrahumanism*: a humanism that begins from the shared condition of the body, refuses the immunities wealth can buy, and treats disgust as the threshold ethical life must cross.

The comparative readings have shown that each thesis extends a lineage: the servant's revolt, from the Papin sisters to Chabrol; the madwoman in the attic, from Brontë to Spivak; the underground man, from Dostoevsky to Ellison; the humanist novel's grace, from Hugo to Steinbeck; the feminist exposure of reproductive labor, from Gilman and Woolf to Akerman and Muylaert. *Parasite* inherits them all and closes each with a negation. Its originality lies not in a new image of class but in the descent of its critique below the threshold at which the traditions it inherits had located the human.

C.7

Coda: From Bunker to Tunnel

Marx's mole worked underground so that one day Europe might leap from its seat and cry, "Well grubbed, old mole!" Bong's mole works underground so that the master's stairs are lit. The task the film leaves to its spectators is to convert the bunker back into a tunnel: to turn odor into speech, lateral violence into solidarity, hidden care into recognized and remunerated work, immunity into shared obligation. None of these conversions occurs in the film. Their absence is its argument.

The last weather is snow. Against the flood, which rose and stank, snow falls, whitens, silences, and covers. It is the weather of the anosmic screen: a world rendered clean, quiet, and odorless, exactly as the spectator receives it. The final image returns us to our own condition. The father is in the ground. The son is beneath the street. The spectator is on the sofa. Between them runs the line, and only the smell crosses it.

Works Cited

All works cited in the thesis, grouped by field. Dates are of original publication or first release; English translations are noted where a specific translation is quoted.

PRIMARY FILM

Bong Joon Ho, dir. *Parasite* (기생충, *Gisaengchung*). Screenplay by Bong Joon Ho and Han Jin-won; cinematography by Hong Kyung-pyo; production design by Lee Ha-jun; editing by Yang Jin-mo; music by Jung Jae-il; English subtitles by Darcy Paquet. Barunson E&A and CJ Entertainment, 2019.

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Keywords

Bong Joon Ho • *Parasite* (2019) • *Gisaengchung* • osmocracy • vicarious corporeality • infrahumanism • reproductive host • social reproduction theory • domestic labor • ethics of care • parasitology • Michel Serres • abjection • disgust • sensory history • olfaction • partition of the sensible • *immunitas* • compressed modernity • *banjiha* • verticality • the uncanny • subalternity • feminist film theory • critical humanism • anosmic spectatorship • class consciousness • Korean cinema